

HARD TO STOMACH

What urban food habits do to Indians

Study finds link between urban diets and gut microbiomes that could be reason behind rising diabetes and other lifestyle diseases in the country

NEWS » PAGE 11



Bill in U.S. Senate seeks three-year pause on H-1B visas

WORLD » PAGE 16



What is the Saudi Arabia-U.S. nuclear deal about?

FAQ » PAGE 14



Para powerlifter Jhandu wins India's first medal at Glasgow

SPORT » PAGE 17

IN BRIEF



Nicobar scheme 'a commercial enterprise': Cong.

NEW DELHI
Congress MP Jairam Ramesh has rejected Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's contention that the Great Nicobar Island Project is a strategically vital national initiative. He said it is "most fundamentally a commercial enterprise" for which a strategic rationale is being "invented". » **PAGE 9**

Gujarat floods: death toll rises to 35 in past 2 days

AHMEDABAD
The death toll from rain-related incidents in Gujarat has risen to 35 over the past two days, with authorities recovering bodies after floodwaters receded and rescue operations concluded. » **PAGE 11**

Lucknow body razes building where 15 died

LUCKNOW
The Lucknow Development Authority on Saturday began demolishing the four-storey building where a fire killed 15 people last month. » **PAGE 3**

CLASSIFIEDS » PAGE 8
MAGAZINE » 8 PAGES

Dharmendra Pradhan quits; CJP calls off stir

We have done it, says Abhijeet Dipke; President appoints Pralhad Joshi as Education Minister

This is a signal to farmers, labourers, poor people to stand up to the oppressive govt., says Rahul Gandhi

Kharge seeks stringent action against those who 'unleashed lathis and pellet guns' on students

Sandeep Phukan
Nistula Hebbur
NEW DELHI

As the student protests over paper leaks spread across different States and snowballed into a major political crisis for the Narendra Modi government, Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as the Education Minister on Saturday, prompting the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) to call off the protests at Jantar Mantar, which had become the epicentre of the agitation for the past 36 days.

President Droupadi Murmu accepted Mr. Pradhan's resignation and appointed Pralhad Joshi as the Education Minister. In his resignation letter addressed to Prime Minister, Mr. Pradhan said he was stepping down on his own account, so that "anti-national" elements do not exploit the situation created by the protests.

Protesters celebrate

As soon as the news of the resignation broke in the afternoon, protesters at Jantar Mantar erupted in joy. "We have done it," CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke told the jubilant crowd.

Activist Sonam Wangchuk, whose hunger strike gave momentum to the protests, termed it a victory



One voice: CJP supporters celebrate at Jantar Mantar after Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

of democracy, peace, patience, and perseverance. "Congratulations CJP, Gen Z of the nation, and thank you all citizens for shedding fear and the fear of fear, and rising up from every corner of the nation," he posted on X.

The resignation came moments before Union Ministers J.P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh met CJP spokespersons Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das for talks to end the protests.

At a joint press conference with the Ministers, the CJP spokespersons said

they are calling the protest off in "good faith" as the government had agreed to their two demands: ₹1 crore to the families of all students who died by suicide after the NEET cancellation and no action against any of the student protesters.

Mr. Nadda said the government will give "honourable compensation" within rules to the families of the students who died by suicide and ensure withdrawal of all FIRs registered against the protesters. "As far as their [CJP]

charter for broader education reforms is concerned, we will deliberate upon and engage with them," he said.

'PM should apologise'

Congratulating the students on their victory, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said exit of Mr. Pradhan is a "symbolic" but huge step in rebuilding the education system.

He, however, said there are still two more demands: anyone who beat up the students should be

held accountable and that the Prime Minister should apologise to the students.

"It is also a signal to other parts of society, farmers, labourers, poor people, anybody whom this regime is attacking and oppressing, there is wisdom and courage in standing up. *Daro mat* (do not fear). Let us get rid of this regime," Mr. Gandhi said.

In a post on X, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said: "The Prime Minister should apologise to youth. There should be strict action against those

Centre to table Bill to strengthen anti-cheating law

NEW DELHI
Union Minister Dr. Jitendra Singh is set to introduce the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, which seeks to strengthen the anti-cheating law, in the Lok Sabha on Monday. The proposed legislation, a copy of which was circulated among MPs on Saturday, significantly toughens the penalties established under the 2024 Act, introduces mandatory two-month investigation deadlines, and imposes penalties reaching up to ₹10 crore for organised crime networks. » **PAGE 9**

Three protesters injured as police open fire in Bihar

PATNA
At least three protesters sustained bullet wounds and several police officers reported injuries from stone-pelting in Siwan district of Bihar on Saturday as a State-wide bandh called by the All India Students' Association over the NEET issue turned violent. While police fired 10 rounds in Siwan, incidents of stone-pelting were reported in several districts, including capital Patna. Though a heavy deployment of the police force was made in the State capital, the large number of students managed to lodge their protest. » **PAGE 10**

who unleashed lathis and pellet guns."

With the first week of the Monsoon Session of Parliament washed out over the Opposition's insistence on Mr. Pradhan's resignation, the government is now expecting both Houses to function.

Amid the jubilation at Jantar Mantar, there were also tense moments, as three senior police officials were injured in stone-throwing near the protest site. Police personnel quickly restored order by using tear gas and resort-

ing to a mild lathi-charge.

Sources said the government had come around to the view on Friday evening that it would be necessary for Mr. Pradhan to resign in order to end the spiralling protests, which appeared to be spreading across the country. With Delhi University set to reopen soon and protests spreading to tier-II cities, discretion was considered the better part of valour, the sources added.

DETAILED COVERAGE
» **PAGES 9 & 10**

Maharashtra TET paper leak accused, aide held from Bihar

Amit Bhelari
Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
PATNA/MUMBAI

The Maharashtra Police on Saturday arrested Bijendra Kumar Gupta, the prime accused in the Maharashtra Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) paper leak case, from Bihar along with his associate Indrajit Singh. Mr. Gupta was picked up from Samastipur, his home district, and arrested in Patna at around 1 a.m.

Later in the day, the two were flown from Patna to Pune and taken to Bhiwandi by road.

A court in Bhiwandi remanded them to police custody till July 30.

"Bijendra Kumar is the mastermind in this case. He has several offences registered against him in different parts of the country. He used to handle the media and the other accused, who used to sell the leaked papers. He was also an accused in two more cases in Odisha. To evade arrest in this case, Bijendra used the fake identity of 'Abhishek Mahato'. He created a



Police bring Bijendra Kumar Gupta and Indrajit Singh, accused in the Maharashtra TET paper leak, to Thane on Saturday. ANI

forged Aadhaar card and a driving licence in that name. He used these documents to buy SIM cards," a senior Maharashtra Police official told *The Hindu*.

Mr. Singh, alias Piku, is accused of harbouring Mr. Gupta in Bihar. Police also alleged that he was involved in Mr. Gupta's activities in Delhi, and was aware of the TET paper leak.

The TET 2026 was postponed on June 27, a day before it was scheduled to be held, after the police in Thane district found that a

portion of the question paper had been leaked and arrested three people.

The SIT found that the racket was spread across Delhi, Agra, Bihar, and Haryana. The TET paper leak, which followed the nationwide controversy over the NEET-UG paper leak, affected nearly six lakh candidates.

With the latest arrests, the total number of accused held in the case has increased to 14.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 9**

Khamenei's jail diary a major attraction at book festival in J&K

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

A book on former Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's years in prison under the Shah regime has found an unexpected readership in Srinagar amid the Iran-U.S. conflict, with copies of his jail diary flying off the shelves at the third edition of the Chinar Book Festival.

The festival, organised by the National Book Trust (NBT), began on July 18 and will conclude on July 26.

The front desk of the stall pavilion has stacks of books authored by Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini, the architect of the 1979 Iranian revolution, and Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed in a joint attack by Israel and the U.S. on February 28 this year.

"Cell No. 14, Khamenei's jail diary, has evoked a huge response. We are selling dozens of copies every day. We had a buyer from the Chenab Valley of J&K



Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's book Cell No. 14 on display at the Chinar Book Festival in Srinagar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

who took 60 copies," said a salesman at the stall.

"The book provides a context to understand the Iranian government and its resolve," said Rashid Ahmad, a student at Kashmir University.

The appeal of Iranian literature is not limited to Shia readers in Kashmir, with Sunnis also visiting the stall and showing interest in the writings. "Reading Iranian literature is essential to understand how the country has married democracy and clergy into one," said Faiz Khan, a political science student.

U.S.'s new 10% tariffs will not affect 45% of exports: Centre

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

A day after the U.S. announced permanent tariffs on imports from 60 trading partners over forced labour goods, the Centre on Saturday said that about 45% of India's exports to the U.S. remains outside the purview of the new 10% tariff.

The government also said that it remained engaged with the U.S. regarding a quota-based system regarding India's textile exports to the U.S.

The statement by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Saturday highlighted that the new 10% tariff is lower than the initially proposed 12.5% on India and some other countries.

It said that "a substantial share" of India's exports to the U.S., such as generic pharmaceuticals, smartphones, and certain other specified products, currently attract zero additional duties and continue to remain outside the

Tariff matters

The new tariffs follow a U.S. investigation into whether trading partners are doing enough to prevent the import of goods made using forced labour

- U.S.'s 10% tariffs are lower than the 12.5% it initially proposed
- Tariffs are on 60 countries that U.S. says have failed to stop the import of goods made using forced labour
- Of the 60, 16 have the same rate as India, while 38 face higher tariffs
- India says 45% of exports to the U.S. will not face these tariffs
- India-U.S. trade deal is still in the works that could alter the tariff arrangement further

scope of the additional 10% tariff.

Apart from these, the Ministry said that products already covered under Section 232 of the U.S. Trade Expansion Act such as steel, aluminium, and auto parts, are not subject to the additional 10% duty.

Further, it pointed out that the tariffs under Section 232, which had been levied last year and that range between 25-50%, are levied equally on nearly all countries, thereby not putting India at a disadvantage

in this regard. "On account of these exemptions, an estimated 45% of India's exports to the U.S. remain outside the purview of the additional 10% duty," the statement said.

It also acknowledged that the remaining 55% of exports will attract the additional 10% duty, but said that India's "tariff incidence is comparatively lower than that for most other economies".

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 9**

After 36 days, it’s a Cockroach Janta party

Roads around Jantar Mantar remain jam-packed well until late evening despite repeated appeals by Delhi Police to disperse; many stay back to click one last selfie at the site of the 'largest and longest student protests' in recent times; CJP volunteers assist police personnel and RAF in guiding students towards transit points; all metro stations reopened and normal entry and exit resumed, says DMRC

‘You should all go home now’: big announcement leaves many in disbelief

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Moments after Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation, the loud cheers at Jantar Mantar on Saturday were punctuated by a roaring announcement by the police - “Saare apne, apne ghar jaiye”.

“Attention, students. The government has accepted all your demands. You should all go home safely now,” the announcement echoed across a jam-packed Tolstoy Road, where a sea of students was celebrating, some standing on the road dividers, some others sitting on the pavements.

Police vehicles fitted with loudspeakers rolled through the roads surrounding Jantar Mantar, urging the crowd to return home “peacefully”.

While the declaration took many by surprise, prompting them to verify the information through their sources, the news of Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) winding up its 36-day agitation soon reached the crowd from the CJP stage.

It took a moment for the people to understand. “I could hardly believe my ears. They [police] already wanted to create confusion so that students would leave. I just picked my phone called one of my friends who was at Jantar Mantar itself. It was ‘not reachable’ twice, but on the third attempt, I was told



Protesters congratulating each other. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

that we have won,” said 22-year-old Vani Dev, who came from Dehradun to participate in the protest.

Paschim Vihar resident Anchal, 17, who goes by her first name only, was also among the crowd returning home but with an aim to come again on Sunday. The moment she was told that the CJP has called off the protest, she froze. “My phone died and I had no idea whom to speak with to verify the piece of news. Then I saw some reporters standing a few metres away discussing the same. I asked them if the news was true and they said yes,” said Ms. Anchal.

Even as police personnel moved through the crowd, requesting protesters to disperse in an orderly manner, a huge loudspeaker was installed near Palika Bazar in Connaught Place from where the police repeatedly informed the people that all gates of Rajiv Chowk metro station had been reopened and could be used to return home. “Saare metro stations khule hain. Aap

ghar jaiye (All metro station gates are open. Please return home),” the announcement said.

Eighteen metro stations on the Blue, Yellow, Violet, and Airport Express (Orange) lines in central Delhi had been closed since 7.30 a.m. for the fourth consecutive day on Saturday owing to security concerns amid the CJP protest.

Confusion over access, however, persisted at Mandi House and Central Secretariat stations, where commuters attempting to exit were told by the metro staff that only entry was permitted, and the exit gates remained closed. The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation later, in a post on X, announced that all metro stations were reopened and normal entry and exit had resumed.

CJP volunteers also joined the Rapid Action Force and the police in guiding students towards transit points.

‘Hope no more leaks’

Despite repeated appeals to disperse, the roads around Jantar Mantar remained packed well until late evening as students celebrated the announcement, exchanged sweets, and clicked what many described as their final selfies at a site that will be remembered for one of the largest and longest student protests in recent times.

“I hope that next year when I sit for the NEET exam, the paper won’t get leaked,” said Ms. Anchal.



It’s a wrap: A student holds aloft a poster at Jantar Mantar after the announcement of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Delhi Police likely to withdraw FIRs as agitation ends: DCP

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Following the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) decision to call off its 36-day Jantar Mantar protest, Delhi Police is likely to withdraw all FIRs registered in connection with the agitation, officials said on Saturday.

“The official communication is yet to come, but the FIRs are likely to be withdrawn now,” said Sachin Sharma, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP), New Delhi. The officer, however, refused to comment on the alleged use of excessive force during the July 20 Parliament protest march, the identification of police officers who were in plainclothes and without badges, and allegations that women were harassed on that day.

Another officer said the police had identified at least 2,500 people through their facial recognition system for various offences linked to the Jantar Mantar protest. “At least 15 FIRs were registered, including those involving charges of attempt to murder, rioting, voluntarily causing hurt and 10 other sections. At least 22 FIRs were registered in connection with pickpocketing cases,” the officer added.

Policemen injured

The DCP said at least three police personnel, including a Special Commissioner, were injured in fresh stone pelting allegedly by protesters celebrating Dharmendra Pradhan’s re-

The police say they had identified at least 2,500 people for various offences linked to the protest

signation at Jantar Mantar. The police later resorted to lathi charge and tear gas shelling to disperse the crowd.

About 5 km from the protest site, the police carried out detentions of around 400 people over the past three days in the South East district alone for unlawful assembly under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita. Around 150 people were detained on Saturday alone.

“We were going to the protest when the police caught us at a picket near Hazrat Nizamuddin police station on Saturday morning,” said Arjun Kumar, a student who was going to the protest site with four other friends. The police later released them.

Meanwhile, the police said Instagram had become a major source of disinformation and that several AI-generated videos were circulating on various social media platforms during the protest.

“There are several AI-generated deepfake videos, such as those of Sonam Wangchuk and Army Lieutenant-General Rajeev Puri. These videos show partial information with deformed content to misguide people,” said Rohit Rajbir Singh, DCP, Central district.

‘Here for our children’: parents flock to protest site on last day

Nikhil M Babu
NEW DELHI

Amid the sea of students and placards at Jantar Mantar, some of the youngest faces were children barely two years old, perched on their parents’ shoulders or walking while clutching their fingers.

For many parents, joining the protest was both an act of defiance and a demand for a better future for their children.

On Saturday evening, after news broke of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation, Salman, 35, arrived at the protest site with his three children, the youngest a one-and-a-half-year-old daughter.

“We were following the movement but couldn’t



In solidarity: Salman, a 35-year-old man, arrived with his children at Jantar Mantar on Saturday to celebrate the success of the youth movement. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

come as we have three children. Today, when we heard the news, we rushed here to celebrate,” Mr. Salman said. He added that his eldest son had urged them to attend.

Similar scenes were witnessed on earlier days as well. Around 11 p.m. on Friday, Kanchan, 34, a make-

up artist from Karol Bagh, arrived with her three-year-old son dressed as a doctor. “It is my second day here. We are here for our children’s future. We can tell them the students here endured lathi charge for them,” she said. “We can also tell them that they were part of it,” she added.

Mission accomplished, a site clean-up for Jantar Mantar’s next cause warriors

Akul Baiju
NEW DELHI

As the 36-day student protest at Jantar Mantar ended on Saturday, the slogans gave way to the sound of brooms sweeping the pavement. Near the entrance to the protest site, close to Janpath metro station, volunteers collected plastic bottles, food wrappers, paper cups and other waste that had accumulated during the sit-in. “We have a full team of volunteers here, with different groups of people contributing,” said Shan Sachdeva from west Delhi’s Paschim Vihar, while picking up litter with fellow protesters.

Some protesters also cleared choked drains, while others collected ban-



Final touches: Student volunteers sweeping the protest site. ANI

ners and posters strewn across the road.

The clean-up effort extended beyond the volunteers. Ragpickers moved through the site collecting recyclable bottles. “While municipal workers are picking up garbage, we are collecting bottles,” said Lo-

kesh Gupta, 34, a ragpicker.

Waste was gathered in large blue plastic bags and stacked along the footpath for collection by the New Delhi Municipal Council.

For many protesters, cleanliness had become a concern well before the demonstration ended.

Arshdeep Singh, 39, from Punjab’s Ludhiana, recalled that after July 20, “there was a mountain of garbage”. He said the problem was not a lack of willingness to keep the site clean but the absence of basic infrastructure.

“On Day 1, I realised that no matter how much litter we picked up, there would be trash until there are no bins,” he added.

The protesters later used social media to coordinate crowdfunding and donations, following which dustbins were placed across the site.

As the last bags of waste were readied for collection, the protesters left the site after ensuring it was clean for those who would gather there next.

Sheet by sheet, stage that amplified students’ voices taken down

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

For 36 days, the makeshift stage at Jantar Mantar stood as the face of the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) agitation. It was a platform for speeches, slogans and solidarity. On Saturday, hours after the protest was called off, it began to disappear, sheet by sheet and banner by banner.

Once the protest’s prominent faces had bid fare-

well to the site, volunteers began dismantling the stage, removing the cloth backdrop, folding flags and placards, unplugging loudspeakers and packing away microphones.

Within hours, only a patch of flattened ground remained where thousands had gathered each day. As the structure came down, emotions ran high among those who stayed back. A few people at the spot raised slogans of ‘Jai Bheem’. The shopkeepers

who sold *dosa* and *idli* behind the stage came to bid farewell to the structure.

Protest’s epicentre

For over a month, the makeshift stage had functioned as the protest’s command centre. It was from here that student leaders and members of the CJP addressed supporters, announced programmes, coordinated volunteers and led slogan-shouting that reverberated across Jantar Man-

tar. The platform became a setting for hunger strikes, cultural performances and daily briefings.

This was not the first time the stage had come down. On July 20, after students marching towards Parliament were stopped by the police and later lathi-charged, the structure was damaged during the crackdown, only to be rebuilt the same night as the protest resumed.

The stage also witnessed some of the move-

ment’s defining moments. It was from here that the police detained climate activist Sonam Wangchuk before he was taken to Safdarjung Hospital.

“The stage is gone, but what happened here will not be forgotten. This place gave us friendships that will last a lifetime. I met Govind from Lucknow here, and we have stood together at this protest for almost a month,” said Sooraj Gupta, a volunteer from Gorakhpur, Uttar Pradesh.



Pack up: A worker dismantling the structure at the Jantar Mantar protest site on Saturday. ANI

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VICTORIS

Rethink decision to hold talks with Karnataka, Stalin tells CM

He asserts that Vijay's visit will serve no purpose besides enabling the govt. to claim it made an effort to resolve the water issue; the Mekedatu dam proposal is in violation of SC's order, he adds

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president and former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Saturday urged Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to abandon his "misguided decision" to visit Karnataka for talks with its government on Tamil Nadu's rights over the Cauvery water.

"If Karnataka refuses to release water to Tamil Nadu, it amounts to contempt of court. Its proposal to construct a dam at Mekedatu is in violation of the Supreme Court's final verdict. Before taking any further steps on an issue as vital as the Cauvery dispute, the Chief Minister should con-



M.K. Stalin

sult all political parties and representatives of farmers' associations," Mr. Stalin said in a statement.

Struggle for T.N.'s rights
He said the struggle to secure Tamil Nadu's rights over the Cauvery had a long history and that those rights had been firmly established through the legal

process. "The Chief Minister should understand the breadth and depth of the issue before proceeding further on such an initiative," he said.

Mr. Stalin said there were doubts over whether the proposed talks were merely an eyewash, as the Congress was in power in Karnataka and was also a constituent of the ruling coalition in Tamil Nadu.

"The visit will serve no purpose other than enabling the government to claim that it made a direct effort by travelling to Karnataka for talks," he said. Mr. Stalin questioned why the Chief Minister had "fallen into Karnataka's trap," charging that its objective was to dilute Tamil Nadu's

rights over the Cauvery waters.

"Delta farmers are furious over the Chief Minister's decision to hold talks," Mr. Stalin said.

Recalling the DMK government's earlier stand, the former CM said it had rejected suggestions to hold direct talks with Karnataka because the neighbouring State had repeatedly failed to honour its commitments and would only prolong the dispute.

"The proposal to construct the Mekedatu dam itself amounts to rejecting Tamil Nadu's rights over the Cauvery. It has always been our stand that there is no purpose in holding talks with Karnataka on this issue," he said.

Timings DELHI

SUNDAY, JUL. 26			
RISE	05:40	SET	19:16
RISE	17:08	SET	02:21
MONDAY, JUL. 27			
RISE	05:40	SET	19:16
RISE	17:56	SET	03:14
TUESDAY, JUL. 28			
RISE	05:41	SET	19:15
RISE	18:38	SET	04:09

Delhi Weather

	max	min
Delhi City	36	28
Safdarjang	36	28
Palam	34	25

Delhi Palam Today 34°C The weather will be warm. Spell of light rain and thundershower with gusty winds may occur at few places. A comfortable night.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow 33°C The weather will be warm. Spell of light rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur. Night will be comfortable.

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OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

OBITUARY



With profound grief, we regret to inform the passing off our beloved mother, **Smt. CHANDRA VISWANATHAN** Wife of Late Shri K. M. Viswanathan, Coimbatore on **22 July 2026** the cremation was held on **23 July 2026**. The rituals will be followed from the 9th day and performed from **30 July 2026** at Venkatesa Theertham, near Sal Baba Temple, Mysore, Chennai.

Kalpna Chaudhary & Family
K. V. Sriram & Family
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THE HINDU
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Government of Himachal Pradesh
Jal Shakti Department

"Notice Inviting e-tender"
The Executive Engineer Jal Shakti Vibhag Division Nalagarh invites online tenders on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh from approved eligible contractors for the following work (s) through e-tendering process:-

S/ No.	Description of work	Estimated Cost	Earnest Money	Cost of tender forms	Stipulated Time period
1.	Restoration of rain damages to GWSS Baddu in Tehsil Ramshehar, District Solan HP (Sub Head:- Repair of UG storage tank 40 KL and providing laying distribution system) (Under PDNA-2023) Sr. No. 9516.	762837/-	15257/-	350/-	One Month
2.	Extension for providing irrigation facility to village Okhoo Dabrota SC Basti from LIS Okhoo in Tehsil Ramshehar district Solan HP (Sub Head:- Providing laying and jointing of GMS pipe in Rising main and supply and erection of Centrifugal pumping machinery 17.5 HP with allied accessories) Under DMFT.	1200949/-	24019/-	500/-	Two Month
3.	Restoration of rain damages to LWSS Jaggar (Old) in Tehsil Ramshehar, District Solan HP (Sub Head:- Construction of UG storage tank 30 KL at Mittian, Repair of source and Providing and laying distribution system) (Under PDNA-2023) Sr. No. 9514.	1448397/-	28968/-	500/-	One Month
4.	Improvement of LWSS SaikundJohriChamyasi in Tehsil Ramshehar District Solan (HP) (SH:- Providing laying jointing testing of GMS pipe, construction of percolation well and supply and erection of submersible pumping machinery with allied accessories) Under DMFT.	4325635/-	86513/-	2000/-	Two Month
4.	Improvement of LWSS SaikundJohriChamyasi in Tehsil Ramshehar District Solan (HP) (SH:- Providing laying jointing testing of GMS pipe, construction of percolation well and supply and erection of submersible pumping machinery with allied accessories) Under DMFT.	4325635/-	86513/-	2000/-	Two Month
5.	Repair and maintenance of TubewellKalibari in Tehsil Nalagarh, District Solan (HP) (SH:-Providing and erection of submersible pump stand by set 75.00 HP in TubewellKalibari GP Golawal linked for drinking).	1134000/-	22680/-	500/-	One Month

1.Last date of filing / uploading the tender through e-tendering: - **31-07-2026 upto 11:00 AM**. The tender forms and other detailed conditions can be obtained from the website www.hpiph.org. Executive Engineer, JSD/Divn.Nalagarh, Distt.Solan (HP).

HP/2167/26-27 **HIM SUCHNA AVAM JAN SAMPARK**

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय
लघु सिंचाई प्रमंडल, हजारीबाग
executiveengineerirri@gmail.com

पत्रांक :- 621 हजारीबाग / दिनांक :- 24.07.2026

शुद्धि पत्र
एतद् द्वारा सूचित किया जाता है कि इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 573 दिनांक 11.07.2026 के द्वारा निर्गत ई - निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या DMFT/MID/HAZARIBAG/F2-13/2026-27 पीओआरनं०- 375165 Minor Irrigation (26-27)#D द्वारा प्रकाशित निविदा में योजना का आंशिक संसोधन निम्न प्रकार किया गया है। शेष शर्तें यथावत् रहेंगी।

- 1). बेवसाईट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि एवं समय - 29.07.2026 at 03:00 PM
- 2). ऑन लाईन ई-निविदा प्राप्त करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय - 10.08.2026 at 05:00 PM
- 3). ऑन लाईन निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय - 10.08.2026 at 05:00 PM
- 4). ई-निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय - 10.08.2026 at 03:00 PM

कार्यपालक अभियंता, लघु सिंचाई प्रमंडल हजारीबाग
PR 385878 Minor Irrigation (26-27)_D

GOVERNMENT OF TAMILNADU
Directorate of Information and Public Relations
Tamil Nadu Government M.G.R. Film and Television Institute
(Affiliated to Tamil Nadu Dr. J. Jayalalithaa Music and Fine Arts University)
C.I.T. Campus, Taramani, Chennai - 600 113.

Online applications are called for filling up of the below mentioned vacancies for Bachelor of Visual Arts Degree Courses for the academic year 2026-2027.

Sl. No.	Course	Quota	No of Vacancy
1.	Cinematography	BC	1
		MBC/DNC	1
		*SIFCC	1
		7.5% Govt. School	1
2.	Digital Intermediate	SC / ST	2
		MBC/DNC	2
		BC	4
		OC	1
		Other State	1
3.	Audiography	7.5% Govt. School	1
		SC / ST	1
		MBC/DNC	2
		BC	4
		Other State	1
4.	Film Editing	MBC/DNC	2
		OC	1
		SC / ST	1
5.	Animation and Visual Effects	SC / ST	1
		BC	2

*Applicants under the SIFCC quota must attach a certificate issued by the South Indian Film Chamber of Commerce, certifying that the applicant's father or mother is associated with the film industry and copy of the ID card Xerox.

For eligibility criteria, age limit, and other relevant details for the above-mentioned courses, applicants are advised to visit the official website: www.filmnstitute.tn.gov.in

Applications, along with all relevant documents and the prescribed application fee to be paid only online and can be submitted from **27.07.2026 to 05.08.2026 till 5.00 P.M.**

Application Fee:
•Scheduled Caste / Scheduled Tribe (SC/ST) applicants belonging to Tamil Nadu: ₹60/-
(A copy of the caste certificate must be attached)
•All other categories: ₹200/-

Director/ Additional Secretary/Principal (FAC)
Tamil Nadu Government M.G.R. Film and Television Institute
DIPR/655/DISPLAY/2026 C.I.T. Campus, Taramani, Chennai - 600 113.

Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs
Government of India

एन बी सी सी
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A Navratna CPSE

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कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियंता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, संभाग-बीकानेर
क्रमांक - 787 दिनांक - 22.07.2026

बिड सूचना संख्या 01 / 26-27 की निविदा संसोधन
(DIPR/C/11007/26 Date 23-06-2026)

इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 527 दिनांक 16.06.2026 द्वारा जारी की गयी बिड सूचना संख्या 01/26-27, स्वीकृत कार्य (EPC MODE) की ऑनलाइन निविदा की दिनांक में निम्नानुसार संसोधन किया जात है:-

क्र. सं.	मद	मूल निविदा में अधिकित दिनांक	संसोधित तिथि
1	बिड जमा रखने/ अपलोड करने की तारीख	22 जून 2026 प्रातः 9:30 बजे से 24 जुलाई 2026 को सायं 06:00 बजे तक	22 जून 2026 प्रातः 9:30 बजे से 13 अगस्त 2026 को सायं 06:00 बजे तक
2	बिड खोलने की तारीख	27 जुलाई 2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे	14 अगस्त 2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे

UBN Code No.- PWD2627/WLCB05176
शेष शर्तें यथावत् रहेंगी। DIPR/C/12940/2026 अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियंता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण-बीकानेर

MANEKSHAW CENTRE
PARADE ROAD, DELHI CANTT-10
NOTICE INVITING TENDER

1. ADG, Adm & Coord invites sealed tender from OEM/ authorized distributors/ vendors for procurement and installation of Digital Conferencing System in Conferencing Hall at Manekshaw Centre, Delhi Cantt-10 as per the terms and condition given in RFP

2. The tender documents (RFP) may be collected from Main Office, Manekshaw Centre, Delhi Cantt-10, between 1000hrs to 1700 hrs wef 27 July 2026 to 07 August 2026 on any working day against submission of tender documents fee of Rs 1500/- (Rupees One Thousand and Five Hundred only) in the form of Demand Draft/Bankers cheque in favour of 'Manekshaw Centre Main Act' or Cash

3. Sealed tender documents as per RFP will be dropped in the tender box placed at the Main Office of Manekshaw Centre by 1700hrs on 20 August 2026.

75
आजारीत
अमृत महोत्सव

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B) DIVISION R.S.PURA

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Short e-NIT No. DRSP/53 of 2026-27 Dated 22-07-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works :-

S. No	Name of Work	Name of Division	Advertised Cost (in Lacs)	Cost of document (in Rs)	Earnest Money (In Rs)	Time Allowed for Complete-on	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	Repair and Renovation of PHC Rehal by way of Construction of separate Ramps for the Ambulance and Patients (Under Recovery and Reconstruction window of NDRF 2026-27)	PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura	47.84	600	2% of Advertised Cost	06 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 04-08-2026	"A", "B" Class

Position of AAA :- Accorded by Directorate of Health Services, Jammu vide order No: 12-DHS/J/P&S of 2026 Dated: 01/07/2026
Position of TS :- Accorded by Superintending Engineer PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu vide order No: 54 of July 2026
Project Authority :- Directorate of Health Services, Jammu
Major Head of Account :- Under Recovery & Re-construction window of NDRF 2026-27

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jktenders.gov.in> as per below schedule :-

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	22-07-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 22-07-2026 to 03-08-2026
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	25-07-2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura
4	Bid submission Start Date	22-07-2026
5	Bid Submission End Date	03-08-2026 upto 1600 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	04-08-2026 on or after 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura. In case mentioned bid opening date happens to be a holiday then Bid shall be opened at the same time on the next working day.
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

1. Bids must be accompanied with cost of Tender document in shape of Treasury Receipt/e-challan in favour of Executive Engineer PWD(R&B) Division R S Pura through Treasury, indicating Treasury Voucher No. & date, e-NIT No. and Date and name of work duly crediting to 0059 (Revenue) and Earnest money/Bid security in shape of CDR/FDR/BG pledged to Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura. The CDR/FDR/BG shall be valid for 45 Days beyond the bid validity period. The original instruments in respect of cost of documents, EMD and relevant documents of L1 be submitted to the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura at the time of allotment.
2. The date of Treasury Challan, Earnest Money/Bid Security must be between the date of start of bid and Bid Submission End Date. However, if the tender for the same work has been re-invited after 1st or More calls, the bidders who have already bid for that work can re-use the same Treasury Challan/Earnest Money/Bid Security in the successive calls for the said work provided there should not be any overwriting or forging on the previously uploaded documents.
3. The electronic bidding system will not allow any late submission of bids after due date and time as per server time. Bidders may modify their bids by uploading their request for modification before the deadline for submission of bids. For this, the bidders need not make any additional payment towards the cost of tender documents. For bid modification and consequential re-submission, the bidder is not required to withdraw his bid submitted earlier. The last modified bid submitted by the bidder within the bid submission time shall be considered as the bid. For this purpose, modification/withdrawal by other means will not be accepted. In online system of bid submission, the modification and consequential submission of bids is allowed any number of times. The bidders may withdraw his bid by uploading their request before the deadline for submission of bids; however, if the bid is withdrawn, the re-submission of the bid is not allowed. No bid shall be modified or withdrawn after the deadline of submission of bids.
4. The date and time of opening of Financial-Bids shall be notified on Web Site www.jktenders.gov.in and conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The Financial-bids of responsive bidders shall be opened online in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura. The date for same shall be intimated separately.
5. The bids for the work shall remain valid for a period of 120 days from the date of opening of Technical bids.
6. The earnest money shall be forfeited, if :-
 - a) Any bidder/tenderer withdraws his bid/tender during the period of bid validity or makes any modifications in the terms and conditions of the bid.
 - b) Failure of Successful bidder to furnish the required performance security within specified time period after issuance of letter of acceptance.
 - c) Failure of Successful bidder to execute the agreement on same day of allotment of work contract as per Chief Engineer PW (R&B) Department Jammu's Circular No. CEJ/G/12660-87 dated 07-10-2021.
7. **Instruction to bidders regarding e-tendering process.**
 - 7.1 Bidders are advised to download bid submission manual from the "Downloads" option as well as from "Bidders Manual Kit" on website www.jktenders.gov.in to acquaint bid submission process.
 - 7.2 To participate in bidding process, bidders have to get 'Digital Signature Certificate (DSC)' as per Information Technology Act-2000. Bidders can get digital certificate from any approved vendors
 - 7.3 The bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic format with digital Signature. No financial bid will be accepted in physical form.
 - 7.4 Bids will be opened online as per time schedule mentioned above.
 - 7.5 Bidders must ensure to upload scanned copy of all necessary documents mentioned in NIT and SBD with technical bid online.

Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division, R.S. Pura
DIPR/J-6549/26, Jul 24 2026

Karnataka BJP
MLC booked
over alleged
hate speech

Imran Gowhar
BENGALURU

An FIR has been registered against C.T. Ravi, BJP MLC, at the Chikkamagaluru Town Police Station following allegations that he made inflammatory and derogatory remarks against the Muslim community during a protest held at Azad Park on Thursday over the NEET examination controversy. The police registered an FIR against Mr. Ravi, charging him with section 353(2) of the BNS, which deals with making, publishing, or circulating false statements, rumours, or reports with intent to create or promote hatred, or enmity between groups on grounds such as religion, race, caste, or community.

Kerala govt. to revive police’s
Sabarimala clean-up project

Punyam Poonkavanam, the community drive launched in 2011, was shelved three years ago over allegations of fund collection; detailed inquiry absolves the nodal officer of all allegations

Hiran Unnikrishnan
PATHANAMTHITTA

Nearly three years after it was shelved, ‘Punyam Poonkavanam’, the Kerala Police’s flagship initiative to keep the Sabarimala pilgrimage zone clean, is set for a comeback. Following an inquiry, the State Home department has exonerated P. Vijayan, Additional Director General of Police (Law & Order) and former nodal officer of the Punyam Poonkavanam project, of all allegations levelled against him. The government has also instructed the officer to revive and continue the project. The



The Kerala Police initiative was aimed at maintaining cleanliness in the Sabarimala zone through voluntary participation. LEJU KAMAL

decision comes shortly after the State government appointed Mr. Vijayan as the Chief Police Coordinator for the upcoming Sabarimala pilgrimage season. Poonkavanam sought to keep the *Sannidhanam*, Pampa and the surrounding pilgrimage zone clean through the voluntary participation of devotees, the Travancore Devaswom Board and various stakeholders. Mr. Vijayan, who had spearheaded the initia-

tive from its inception, was appointed its nodal officer by the Kerala High Court in 2015. Under his watch, Punyam Poonkavanam had evolved into a large volunteer movement. The project, however, ran into turbulence after the High Court initiated *suo motu* proceedings on the basis of a report submitted by the Sabarimala Special Commissioner over allegations of fund collection by a project coordinator. Acting on the court’s directives, the then Chief Police Coordinator for Sabarimala held a probe and submitted a report, which contained adverse findings against Mr. Vijayan.

‘RSS and BJP are targeting basic structure of Constitution’

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and the BJP-led Union government are targeting the basic structure of the Constitution because it is standing in the way of their Hindu Rashtra project, N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Limited, has said. He was here on Monday to deliver a lecture on ‘Un-making the Republic: How Hindutva authoritarianism is dismantling the basic structure of Indian Consti-

tution’ in memory of Chintta Ravindran, filmmaker and writer. Mr. Ram pointed out that Hindutva authoritarianism had been attacking the basic structure doctrine, which was not a fixed code, but a “judicially administered standard.” Because of this reason, its implementation depends on the character, independence, and capability of the judiciary to stand up to executive pressure, particularly from Hindutva authoritarianism, which was ruthless and relentless. “It is an open secret that



N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Limited, delivering a lecture in Kozhikode on Saturday. K. RAGESH

the RSS has long regarded the Constitution unsuitable for a Hindu majoritarian country. So, the basic structure stands in the way

of what the RSS wants to achieve [a Hindu Rashtra]. When it comes to amending the Constitution, it is the open-endedness and

perceived vulnerability of the basic structure doctrine that the RSS, its mass political arm, the BJP, and the Union government it leads, has been and will be targeting,” Mr. Ram said.

CJP protest The former Editor-in-Chief of *The Hindu* said that the protest led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) in the national capital reflected a rage of grievances and frustrations and a loss of hope. “An intelligent government would have engaged with them early on. Epi-

sode after episode, they did not do it,” he said. Mr. Ram also criticised the way in which the police attacked the non-violent protesters. “Democratic and progressive parties should support them and not take over them. This student and youth movement will succeed in teaching the Modi government a lesson,” he said. Actor Bhavana’s brother, Jayadevan, received the Chintta Ravindran memorial award on her behalf. The event was organised by the Chintta Ravindran Foundation.

SDM gets delivery
agent jailed for ‘less
items in parcel’; may
get show-cause notice

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

A Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM) in Madhya Pradesh’s Panna district has sent a delivery executive to jail after he did not find the items ordered through an online platform. The district administration is toying with the idea of issuing a show-cause notice to the SDM.

Video on Internet A video of the purported incident that took place on July 21 and a conversation has surfaced on the Internet where executive Vijay Kushwaha can be heard telling Shahnagar SDM Rammivas Choudhary that he had delivered a sealed packet and that he [Choudhary] could file for a refund under the platform’s return policy. The incident took place at Mr. Choudhary’s office. He had ordered two sets of two cell phone covers but received only one in each box. “You will go to jail within two seconds. You have taken the money for two [cell phone covers] but there is only one. Are you returning the money or not? I am not filing for a return,” Mr. Choudhary reportedly told the executive. Mr. Kushwaha then said, “I have given a packed box. I cannot do anything about it. Why did you abuse me?” The SDM’s staff then told him to get out of the room as Mr. Choudhary di-

Prima facie the incident seemed to be a case of abuse of power: Panna SP Nivedita Naidu rected them to call the police. After this, the delivery executive narrated the incident in the video. Panna Collector Usha Parmar told *The Hindu* that while the delivery executive was released on bail on July 22, the district administration is asking the SDM to give details of the incident. When contacted, Mr. Choudhary alleged that Mr. Kushwaha was “talking rudely” and also “banged his hands on the table”. “He gave the parcel to my staff and left. When we called him within minutes, he said he had travelled far and refused to come back initially. So, I scolded him. When he came back, he entered my chamber with mobile video recording on. I asked him for a refund but he refused and said we could call the police,” Mr. Choudhary said. Panna Superintendent of Police Nivedita Naidu said, “*Prima facie* the incident seemed to be a case of abuse of power.” “The SDM and his staff did not tell the police that the matter was related to online delivery. They just alleged that the man was disturbing peace inside the SDM office. They did not tell us the whole matter,” Ms. Naidu said.

INBRIEF



Karnataka Cabinet expansion
talks likely to start this week

The Congress high command is expected to resume discussions on the long-pending Karnataka Cabinet expansion next week. Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, former Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, and KPCC president B.K. Hariprasad reportedly held discussions with AICC general secretaries K.C. Venugopal and Randeep Singh Surjewala on Saturday on the proposed expansion and the number of legislators to be inducted into the Ministry. The two general secretaries were in Bengaluru to oversee the process of appointing District Congress Committee presidents.

TDB to appoint new chief
priest for Sabarimala temple

Kandararu Brahmadathan of the Thazhamon Madhom will be appointed the *Tantri* (chief priest) of the Sabarimala Temple, the Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) decided on Saturday. Mr. Brahmadathan, who is the son of former *tantri* Kandararu Rajeevaru, will hold the position for one year from August 17. Earlier this month, citing ill health, Mr. Rajeevaru had requested that he be relieved from the position. Mr. Rajeevaru had also been arraigned as an accused in the Sabarimala gold theft case.

Kerala govt. giving in to Sangh
agenda: Pinarayi on Waqf row

The Kerala government’s move to appoint non-Muslim members to the Kerala Waqf Board amounts to subscribing to the divisive agenda of the Sangh Parivar, Opposition Leader Pinarayi Vijayan has said. Mr. Vijayan alleged that Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan was misleading the people of the State on the issue. The Waqf Act seeks the inclusion of two non-Muslim members and one Shia member on the Board. He said that despite amendments to the Act over the years, non-Muslims were never appointed as members.

15 held in ₹22-lakh holiday
package fraud in Hyderabad

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Fifteen organisers and holiday consultants associated with a holiday membership fraud operated under the name The Pacific Holiday World have been arrested by the Gachibowli police in Hyderabad for luring customers to purchase holiday packages through false promises and deceptive marketing practices. According to the police, the company, registered as 4R Seasons Holidays Private Limited with its registered office at Kalkaji in New Delhi, was operating promotional campaigns in Hyderabad by targeting visitors. Investigators said the company deployed marketing executives to

The fraud came to light after customers complained of undelivered services despite paying for memberships distribute free gift coupons at prominent malls and commercial establishments while collecting visitors’ mobile phone numbers. The customers were informed that they had been selected for attractive holiday benefits and were later invited over phone to promotional meetings held at star hotels, including the Radisson Hotel in Gachibowli. Company representatives persuaded customers to purchase holiday memberships by promising lux-

ury holiday packages. Customers were pressured into making immediate payments through limited-period discounts, complimentary gifts and assurances of luxurious holiday stays. However, several customers reportedly did not receive the promised services after paying for the membership, leading to allegations of cheating. Acting on a complaint, Gachibowli police conducted verification at the Radisson Hotel. Based on the complaint, all 15 organisers and holiday consultants associated with the company were apprehended for investigation. The investigation has so far identified 19 victims who were collectively cheated of around ₹22 lakh.

Stone & spirit



Cultural pulse: Artistes perform a traditional dance at the Undavalli Caves in Guntur district during the Andhra Pradesh Telugu Mahotsavam, celebrating the region’s rich cultural heritage, on Saturday. G.N. RAO

Centre considering
two new dry ports in
A.P. and Telangana

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Union Minister for Ports and Shipping Sarbananda Sonowal has informed the Lok Sabha that a proposal to designate Sri City in Andhra Pradesh a dry port is being examined by the Inter-Ministerial Committee under Customs. It is also looking at a similar proposal for Chityala in Telangana. To a question from Vijayawada MP Kesineni Sivanath on July 23 on the creation of export-import logistics infrastructure in Andhra Pradesh, Mr. Sonowal said the inter-ministe-

rial panel had approved proposals for eight dry ports, including Fatehpur in Telangana. Another nine new proposals, including Sri City (Tirupati district) and Chityala (Nalgonda), were under active consideration. “Priority is given to areas where industrial demand is high but infrastructure is limited,” the Union Minister said. He further said the Centre was committed to connecting the Telugu States to an international-standard logistics network, while noting that Sri City was crucial to Andhra Pradesh’s economic growth.

Tea leaves take flight from fields to
factories as Munnar firm uses drones



A drone transporting green leaves from tea fields at Lockhart Estate in Devikulam in Idukki. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sandeep Vellaram
IDUKKI

In a significant technological step forward for the plantation sector, and in a first, a tea company has begun using drone-based transport to move freshly harvested green leaves from tea fields to weightment centres and processing factories in Kerala’s Idukki. According to company officials, trials for the drone transportation system were successfully conducted at the Lockhart Estate, operated by Harrison’s Malayalam Limited (HML) near Devikulam in Munnar. Established during the British

era, Lockhart is one of the region’s oldest tea plantations. HML vice-president Anil George confirmed the successful trial of the payload drones. “For the trial phase, we used bags weighing 12 kilograms, which was a big success. Following these positive results, we plan to deploy drones with a carrying capacity of 40 to 50 kilograms. The drones can carry the load five to 10 kilometres,” Mr. George said. **Faster transfer** This initiative, undertaken in collaboration with technology partner Tropo-works, aims to streamline

field logistics, boost productivity, minimise manual handling, and ensure faster transfer of green leaves to the factory. Mr. George noted that tractors are currently used to haul tea leaves across estates. “Fuel costs for vehicles are rising. By adopting drone technology, we can cut fuel expenses and speed up leaf transport,” he said. “Today, all our estates rely on drone-assisted systems for crop protection and field operations,” Mr. George added. “We will continue working closely with tech partners, drone operators, and AI specialists to accelerate innovation across our plantation business.”

ADVERTISEMENT

SVAMITVA YOJANA TRANSFORMS MADHYA PRADESH WITH SECURE LAND RIGHTS AND FINANCIAL EMPOWERMENT

Free registration of property documents, easier bank loans and stronger legal ownership mark a new chapter in rural governance under Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav, building on Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of digitally mapped villages

‘SVAMITVA’ USHERS IN NEW ERA OF RURAL OWNERSHIP IN MADHYA PRADESH



Madhya Pradesh has emerged as one of the country’s foremost success stories in implementing the Centre’s ambitious ‘SVAMITVA’ (Survey of Villages and Mapping with Improved Technology in Village Areas) Scheme, converting millions of rural homes into legally recognised assets that unlock economic opportunity.

Driven by the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who launched the nationwide initiative to provide clear ownership rights to rural residents through drone-based surveys, the programme has received decisive momentum in the state under the leadership of Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav. The state government has expanded the scope of the scheme beyond issuing property cards by ensuring that beneficiaries receive

registered ownership documents free of cost, removing one of the biggest hurdles faced by rural families in accessing formal banking services.

In a landmark decision, the Madhya Pradesh Cabinet approved the registration of property documents for all eligible ‘SVAMITVA’ beneficiaries at government expense. Nearly 48.32 lakh rural property holders will receive legally registered ownership documents without paying registration fees, cess or other statutory charges. The state government will spend over Rs. 3,800 crore to implement the initiative.

The decision addresses a long-standing challenge. Although lakhs of villagers had received ownership certificates under the ‘SVAMITVA’ Scheme, many banks were reluctant to accept those documents as adequate legal proof for sanctioning loans. With

formal registration, these documents will now carry stronger legal validity, enabling beneficiaries to mortgage their properties and obtain institutional credit for agriculture, small businesses, self-employment, education and other productive purposes.

Officials believe the move will fundamentally change the rural economy by transforming residential properties into bankable financial assets while simultaneously strengthening legal ownership, reducing disputes and simplifying inheritance and property transfers.

The state has also planned an extensive awareness campaign to ensure every eligible family understands the benefits of registration and the opportunities created by the scheme.

OPENING NEW DOORS FOR LOCAL DEVELOPMENT

Nearly complete across the State

Implementation of the ‘SVAMITVA’ Scheme has advanced rapidly across Madhya Pradesh.

Drone surveys have been carried out in more than 42,000 villages across all districts. Survey work has been completed in over 40,500 villages, resulting in nearly 66 lakh property records. More than 46 lakh property documents have already been distributed, while the remaining eligible beneficiaries are being covered in subsequent phases.

State officials estimate that implementation is almost 96 per cent complete, placing Madhya Pradesh among the country’s leading performers under the national programme.

Prime Minister’s direct engagement strengthens implementation

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has remained closely associated with the implementation of the ‘SVAMITVA’ Scheme, periodically interacting with beneficiaries through nationwide virtual programmes and electronically distributing property cards across the country.

In one such major initiative, more than 15.63 lakh beneficiaries in Madhya Pradesh received e-Property Cards during a nationwide distribution programme led by the Prime Minister.

These events have reinforced the objective of providing rural citizens with legally recognised ownership rights while integrating village properties into the formal financial system.

Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav has participated in state-level programmes and consistently emphasised timely implementation, ensuring that benefits reach eligible households across Madhya Pradesh.

Revenue administration accelerates implementation

The Revenue Department has maintained close monitoring of the programme through regular review meetings and video conferences with district administrations.

Alongside reviewing revenue cases, the implementation of the farmer registry, and revenue collection, senior officials directed all districts to accord the highest priority to completing the ‘SVAMITVA’ Scheme.

Pending publication of ownership records has been expedited, with districts instructed to complete remaining

formalities within prescribed timelines so that beneficiaries receive their documents without delay.

State-level monitoring of pending revenue cases through the Revenue Case Management System has also been strengthened to improve administrative efficiency.

Technology brings transparency

One of the defining features of the ‘SVAMITVA’ Scheme has been the extensive use of modern technology.

Drone surveys have mapped village habitation areas with remarkable precision, creating accurate digital property records for millions of rural residents.

Ground verification, public publication of records, objection hearings and final approvals have been completed under clearly defined procedures, making the process more transparent and reducing the scope for future disputes.

In several districts, administrative action was also initiated wherever discrepancies were detected during verification, reflecting the government’s



emphasis on accountability and accuracy.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS

Free registration for rural families

The Madhya Pradesh Cabinet has approved free registration of property documents for nearly 48.32 lakh ‘SVAMITVA’ beneficiaries, with the state

bearing registration fees and related charges worth more than Rs. 3,800 crore.

Bank loans made easier

Legally registered ownership documents will allow rural households to use their properties as collateral for institutional credit, improving access to finance and encouraging entrepreneurship.

Statewide drone mapping

Drone surveys have covered over 42,000 villages, creating millions of digital property records and bringing transparency to rural land administration.

Strong monitoring

The Revenue Department is conducting continuous reviews to ensure timely publication of ownership records, speedy disposal of pending cases and completion of the scheme across all districts.

Special village-level campaigns

District administrations have organised verification drives, awareness programmes and distribution camps to ensure eligible beneficiaries receive their ownership documents efficiently.

Technology-driven governance

Digital mapping, online land records and systematic verification have strengthened legal certainty while reducing the likelihood of future land disputes.

Prime Minister’s vision, State’s execution

The ‘SVAMITVA’ Scheme reflects Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of empowering rural India through secure property rights. Under the leadership of Chief Minister Dr. Yadav, Madhya Pradesh has translated that vision into one of the country’s most comprehensive land ownership programmes, laying the foundation for stronger rural livelihoods, financial inclusion and sustained economic growth.

DRIVING ECONOMIC GROWTH AND GOOD GOVERNANCE

Districts conduct special camps to speed up work

Across Madhya Pradesh, district administrations organised extensive field-level activities to ensure the scheme’s timely implementation.

Special camps were held in gram panchayats and tehsils for:

- Ground verification of surveyed properties
- Updating Records of Rights
- Publication of ownership records
- Disposal of claims and objections
- Farmer Registry work

Collectors reviewed preparations through regular meetings and directed officials to ensure smooth distribution of ownership documents while arranging live broadcasts of the Prime Minister’s address during national programmes.

The coordinated approach ensured that implementation reached villages through district, block and gram panchayat-level events.

Property ownership becomes an economic asset

For decades, thousands of rural families possessed houses and residential land without legally recognised ownership documents. The registration initiative changes that reality.

Registered ownership documents now provide rural households with:

- Easier access to bank loans
- Stronger legal ownership
- Better acceptance by financial institutions
- Simplified inheritance and transfer of property

- Reduced property disputes
- Greater opportunities for entrepreneurship and self-employment

The government expects easier access to institutional finance to encourage investment in agriculture, rural enterprises and small businesses while strengthening overall financial inclusion.

Madhya Pradesh among India’s best-performing states

The success of the ‘SVAMITVA’ Scheme forms part of a broader development narrative in Madhya Pradesh.

The state has consistently ranked among the country’s leading performers in implementing flagship programmes of the Government of India.

It has achieved full or near-complete implementation in several major schemes, including:

- PM-Kisan Samman Nidhi
- PM Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana
- SVAMITVA
- BharatNet
- Kisan Credit Card
- Atal Pension Yojana

The state has also exceeded national targets under schemes such as PM SVANIDHI, the Amrit Sarovar Mission and the Soil Health Card programme, while making substantial progress under the Jal Jeevan Mission, Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, Ayushman Bharat and rural road connectivity programmes.



Classifieds

LIFE MADE SIMPLE

Matrimonial

BRINGING PEOPLE TOGETHER

INDEX OF MATRIMONIAL

BRIDEGROOMS WANTED

BRIDES WANTED

BRIDES & GROOMS WANTED

Classification Common for Brides, Bridegrooms, Brides & Grooms

ASSAMESE

AWADHI

BENGALI

BHOJPURI

BIHARI

CHHATTISGARHI

ENGLISH

GUJARATI

HARYANI

HINDI

KANNADA

KASHMIRI

KONKANI

MALAYALAM

MANIPURI

MARATHI

MARWARI

NEPALI

ORIYA

PARSI

PUNJABI

SAURASHTRA

SINDHI

TAMIL

TELUGU

TULU

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ADVOCATE

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DEFENCE

DOCTOR

ENGINEER

FINANCE/ BANKING

GOVERNMENT/ QUASI-GOVERNMENT

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BENGALI, KAYASTHA

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From Page One

‘U.S.’s 10% tariffs will not affect 45% of exports’



India says it continues working with the U.S. government regarding textile exports. FILE PHOTO

The office of the U.S. Trade Representative (USTR) on Thursday released the final findings of its investigation on whether the U.S.’s trade partners were doing enough to prevent the import of goods made using forced labour. As a result of this investigation, it decided to levy a tariff of 10% on 17 economies, including India. While an additional five – the European Union, Taiwan, Japan, Korea, and Switzerland – will receive a lower effective tariff rate, the remaining 38 countries that were investigated will receive a higher tariff than India’s.

“The Government of India remained closely engaged with the USTR throughout the investigation through detailed written submissions and in-person consultations, including participation in public hearings,” the Ministry statement said, adding “as a result of these sustained efforts, India has been placed in the lower tier of additional tariffs under the final measures, providing a relative advantage to Indian exports in key sectors.”

‘Working with the U.S.’

In its report, the USTR also provided for the establishment of a “textile mechanism” in the form of tariff-rate quotas (TRQs) for Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, and Malaysia, to encourage these countries to import U.S. cotton and textile goods, “in order to reduce reliance on inputs from other sources that are more likely to contain forced labour inputs”.

India was not included in this mechanism, but India said it continues working with the U.S. government regarding India’s textile exports.

Highlighting that the textile specific mechanism referenced in the final measures “is yet to be established and operationalised,” the Ministry said, “India continues to engage with the U.S. on this matter as part of the ongoing negotiations for the India-U.S. Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA).”

The government “remains committed” to working with the U.S. towards the early conclusion of the India-U.S. BTA, the Ministry said.

Maharashtra TET paper leak accused, aide held

The Maharashtra Special Task Force (STF) and the Special Investigation Team (SIT), which are probing the case, had raided the Quick Digital Cyber Cafe on Kachhari Road in Hajipur, Vaishali district, on July 1. Three individuals, including cafe operator Sonu Kumar, were taken into custody and questioned. The investigation also established a link between Sonu Kumar and Gupta.

Sources in the Hajipur police said that Kumar’s confession led to the arrest of a cyber cafe operator in Hajipur. Earlier, the police had also arrested Pawan Kumar from Delhi and Hariom Panu from Haryana—close associates of Gupta.

Earlier, a team comprising the Bihar STF and the Bhiwandi police from Maharashtra’s Thane district had arrested Gupta’s wife, Suman Kumari, from Patna’s Agamkuan area on July 1, based on her call records and financial transactions.

Union govt. circulates Bill to strengthen anti-cheating law

Centre to introduce the Bill in Parliament on Monday; it proposes to introduce mandatory two-month investigation deadlines, designated Special Fast Track Courts, steep financial penalties

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

In a move to strengthen the anti-cheating law, the Union government has proposed the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, a copy of which was circulated among members of Parliament on Saturday.

Union Minister Dr. Jitendra Singh will introduce the Bill in the Lok Sabha on Monday.

The proposed legislation significantly toughens the penalties established under the 2024 Act, introduces mandatory two-month investigation deadlines, along with designated Special Fast Track Courts, and steep financial penalties reaching up to ₹10 crore for organised crime networks.

Maximum imprisonment sentences for individual and institutional offenders have been increased, alongside a steep hike in financial penalties, according to the proposed Bill.

Specialised Enforcement Units enable the Un-

Tougher rules, bigger fines

The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 significantly escalates the cost of committing or facilitating exam malpractices

■ Under Section 10(1) (General offences): Jail: 5-10 years (from 3-5 years); Fine: up to ₹50 lakh (from ₹10 lakh) ■ Under Section 10(2) (Service provider fines): Fine: up to ₹5 crore (from ₹1 crore) ■ Under Section 10(2) (Service provider directors/management): Jail: 3-10 years;	Fine: ₹5 crore (from ₹1 crore) ■ Under Section 10(3) (In-charge personnel): Jail: 5-10 years (from 3-10 years); Fine: ₹5 crore (from ₹1 crore) ■ Under Section 11(1) (Organised crime): Minimum jail: 7 years (from 5 years); Fine: up to ₹10 crore (from ₹1 crore)
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ion government to constitute dedicated Special Task Forces (STF) to take exclusive charge of investigation efforts.

All investigations – whether conducted by local police, Central Investigating Agencies, or an STF – must be concluded within 60 days.

State governments and Union Territory administrations will designate Sessions Courts to conduct trials on a continuous, day-to-day basis. Trials must wrap up within three months of the chargesheet being filed. High Court appeals will be heard by a Di-

vision Bench (two judges) and must also be resolved within a three-month period.

To address prolonged legal delays, the Bill introduces Sections 12A and 12B, establishing an uninterrupted procedural pipeline.

Courts cannot grant adjournments beyond the following day without writing explicit, exceptional reasons.

Transfer of cases

All ongoing cases under the 2024 Act will immediately transfer to the newly designated Special Fast

Track Courts and must be completed within three months of transfer.

States and Union Territories are mandated to appoint Special Public Prosecutors under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023 to handle these trials exclusively.

Appeals against bail orders, judgments, or sentences must be filed within 30 days (with a strict absolute ceiling of 90 days for special delays) and will be adjudicated by a two-judge High Court Bench.

Recent incidents of paper leaks and malpractices have necessitated urgent structural overhauls to safeguard transparent and merit-based selections.

“The objective of the Act is to bring greater transparency, fairness, and credibility, and to inspire confidence in the public examination system, Dr. Jitendra Singh noted.

“The amendments ensure time-bound investigations, speedy trials, and enhanced deterrence against organised crime groups and institutions,” he said.

FIR registered on Goyal’s complaint over deepfake video

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Piyush Goyal

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Saturday alleged that an AI-generated deepfake video had “maliciously” altered his remarks to the media outside Parliament to spread misinformation, and said he had lodged a police complaint, following which an FIR was registered at the Chanakya-puri police station.

In a post on X, Mr. Goyal said the manipulated clip was being circulated on social media with the intent to mislead the public and warned that “strict legal action” would be taken against those involved in creating, disseminating or promoting it.

He also asserted that irresponsible misuse of artificial intelligence to mislead the public cannot and will not be tolerated.

Government sources said many social media links carrying the AI-generated video had since been taken down.

The PIB’s fact-check unit had on Friday said Pakistani propaganda accounts were circulating the fabricated video, which falsely

portrayed Mr. Goyal as making threatening remarks against students protesting over alleged irregularities in NEET. Mr. Goyal urged the public to rely only on verified sources of information. “I have complete faith that India’s aware and tech-savvy citizens, especially our youth, will not fall prey to such misinformation,” he said.

The manipulated video surfaced against the backdrop of the recently concluded student protests organised by the Cockroach Janata Party at Jantar Mantar, New Delhi. Social media has witnessed a surge in content related to the demonstrations, and authorities have repeatedly cautioned users against relying on unverified videos and posts circulating online.

Great Nicobar project ‘most fundamentally a commercial enterprise’: Jairam Ramesh

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI



Jairam Ramesh

In his latest letter, Congress MP Jairam Ramesh has rejected Defence Minister Rajnath Singh’s contention that the Great Nicobar Island Project is a strategically vital national initiative. He reiterated that the scheme is “most fundamentally a commercial enterprise” for which a strategic rationale is being “invented.”

Mr. Ramesh was responding to Mr. Singh’s reply of July 17, which had itself answered two of the MP’s earlier letters.

Over the last two years, Mr. Ramesh has written repeatedly on the project to four Union Ministers – Environment, Forests and Climate Change; Tribal Affairs; Ports, Shipping and Waterways; and Defence – three of whom, he said,

have replied.

In the recent letter, Mr. Ramesh argued that the trans-shipment port at Galathea Bay lay at the project’s heart and accounted for about half its budget, making it commercial “by definition.” The dual-purpose airport, the only component with a defence focus, required just 5% of the 166 sq. km sought and about 10% of the budget, he said, calling claims of the project’s overall strategic importance an “exag-

geration.” He added that the Draft Master Plan for 2047 envisaged cruise tourism, casinos, theme parks and a finance hub, reading “more like an ambitious real estate project.”

Mr. Ramesh also reiterated that expanding the existing INS Baaz at Campbell Bay would carry lower environmental and social costs than the greenfield airport, citing seven concerns – among them the felling of two forest-covered hills, destruction of Shompen tribal land and impacts on international bird flyways – that he said remained unrefuted. He questioned the confidentiality of the National Green Tribunal (NGT)-appointed High-Powered Committee report and urged the Minister to consult retired naval officers who have questioned the defence reasoning.

Families must connect with the youth through dialogue, not dictation, says RSS chief

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI



Mohan Bhagwat

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Friday stressed that the biggest challenge before families today is connecting with the younger generation through dialogue rather than authority, asserting that “today’s youth need discussion, not dictation.”

Mr. Bhagwat was speaking at an event organised under the banner of Vishwa Mangalya Sabha, an organisation “focused on empowered motherhood, cultural harmony and universal wellbeing”, as per its website.

The event took place at Ambedkar International Centre, just a kilometre away from Jantar Mantar, where students were protesting against exam paper leaks under the banner of

the Cockroach Janta Party.

In his speech, the RSS chief stressed that parenting styles must evolve with changing times.

“There was a time when obedience came naturally. When we were children, if our mother or father said something, there were no arguments. Once they had spoken, that was the end of the discussion. We also had deep faith in them. We believed they had seen more of life than we had, and that their experience

would guide us in the right direction,” he said.

Stressing how things are different presently, he added, “The younger generation asks questions, and rightly so. They are constantly exposed to countless influences through modern media and materialistic culture, which often leaves them confused. It is our responsibility to help them find clarity amidst that confusion.”

He said that children need a strong sense of belonging. “Today, parenting has to be about discussion; not orders, but consensus,” he said.

Stating that children today judge parents by their actions and not directions, he said that the younger generation won’t accept things simply because they’re told about them. They want ‘us’ to practise what we preach, he added.

Sarnath added to UNESCO Heritage List

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India’s ancient Buddhist site of Sarnath in Uttar Pradesh was on Saturday inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List. The decision was taken during the ongoing meeting of the UNESCO World Heritage Committee’s 48th session in Busan, South Korea.

“New inscription on the @UNESCO #WorldHeritage List: Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath, #India,” UNESCO posted on X. This is India’s 45th site to join the list.

PM Narendra Modi hailed the inscription, stating that the site has a deep connection with Lord Buddha, whose timeless message of wisdom, compassion, and harmony inspires the world.

After 12 years in power, Dharmendra Pradhan’s exit exposes BJP’s shrinking political legroom

NEWS ANALYSIS

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

The resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, a demand sustained over long weeks by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and young protesters, is not the first instance of a Minister resigning from the Narendra Modi government, nor is it the first time this government has blinked in the face of a strong protest movement.

The Union government under Mr. Modi walked back on the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement (Amendment) Ordinance in 2015, after repromulgating it thrice. Former Minister of



CJP supporters celebrate as Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigns, at Jantar Mantar, on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

State for External Affairs M.J. Akbar resigned in 2018 after allegations were levelled against him in the #MeToo movement. The Farm Laws were withdrawn after months of protests by farmers at Delhi’s doorstep in 2021. Mr. Pradhan’s resignation may be seen as a part of this series of reversals. On the

other hand, the government carried the day in other protests, including by the students of the Jawaharlal Nehru University here in 2016, and the widespread protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act in 2019-2020, in which the polarisation suited the BJP’s base. All of this is, of course, a product of

political calculations, of whether the government feels it can remain strong on its point or whether it needs to concede now to live to fight another day.

Challenge for the govt.

The CJP-led protests have been a political challenge for the Modi government, now in its 12th year. The protesters are young citizens, and they cut across lines of caste, community, and even class. Many could also have hailed from families that may have voted for Mr. Modi in successive Lok Sabha elections.

The protests also bring to the fore another reality. Gen Z, as they are termed, are now in their late teens and early 20s and were children when Mr. Modi assumed power. They do not recall the acts of omission and commission by previous governments, and in-

stead want a response to the way things are run now, and have been in the past 12 years.

Every government takes decisions based on its own political calculations. What should not be part of that calculation is obduracy over whether a Minister will stay or go, or whether or not genuine demands by embattled students should be met.

In this, the 12th year and the third iteration of a BJP-led government, the Modi government has very limited legroom and manoeuvrability for taking political risks in events such as the CJP protests. Young protesters have shown the government that a new cohort of leaders and voters is nipping at its heels. To engage with them, the government may have to shake its 12-year-old playbook.

Ex-Chhattisgarh PSC chief arrested in paper leak case

Press Trust of India
RAIPUR

The Enforcement Directorate on Saturday arrested a former Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (PSC) chairman Taman Singh Sonwani here on money laundering charges in an alleged examination paper leak case, officials said.

The probe pertains to the “leak” of question papers and “manipulation” of the State service examinations conducted in 2020 and 2021 by the Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission. Officials said Mr. Sonwani was taken into custody under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

He is being produced before a special PMLA

court in Raipur, where the ED will seek his custodial remand, an official said.

The money laundering investigation stems from a 2024 Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) FIR. The CBI case was booked based on a State police complaint that was filed after the BJP came to power in Chhattisgarh. He was arrested in 2024. The ED accused Mr. Sonwani of leaking question papers and rigging selections in exchange for illegal gratification favouring his own relatives and candidates who paid bribes. The probe found that “bribes” were collected partly in cash and partly laundered through a family-controlled “samiti” in the guise of CSR donation for a “non-existent” college.

Memes to movement

The NEET paper leak and a viral courtroom jab sparked off a youth-led political movement and nationwide protests seeking accountability and the resignation of the Education Minister



MAY 3: About 22 lakh candidates attend NEET-UG 2026

MAY 12: Exam cancelled following widespread paper leak allegations

MAY 16: Abhijeet Dipke creates a satirical page Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on X. His first tweet, "What if all cockroaches come together?" gets massive response

MAY 21: Govt. issues notice to X to withhold CJP's X handle in India

MAY 23: Govt. invokes IT Act to block party's official website

MAY 15: CJI Surya Kant makes controversial "cockroach" remarks



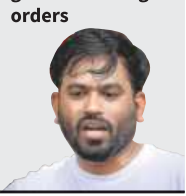
JUNE 6: CJP holds first street protest at Jantar Mantar; demands Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation

JUNE 11: Protesters release five-point manifesto demanding exam reforms, student compensation

JUNE 20: They launch indefinite dharna at Jantar Mantar; calls for Pradhan's resignation get louder

JUNE 28: Activist Sonam Wangchuk

JUNE 8: Mr. Dipke files writ petition in Delhi HC over govt's blocking orders



joins protest, begins hunger strike

JULY 20: CJP's meeting with J.P. Nadda fails to reach consensus; CJP alleges they were kept under "virtual detention"; demands all future talks happen at a neutral venue

■ Student protesters take out 'Chalo Sansad' march which ends in police lathi-charge; over 100 injured

JULY 21-23: Opposition leaders,

JULY 18: On 21st day of his fast, Mr. Wangchuk is forcibly removed by Delhi Police from the venue



media personalities declare solidarity, condemn police action. Movement swells to other major cities

JULY 22: Delhi HC asks police to explain their actions; SC declines to take suo motu cognisance of the same

■ CJP Instagram page blocked and restored within 30 minutes

■ Centre informs Parliament its ready for 'detailed

JULY 23: Prime Minister reaches out to protesters via X; govt. promises to compensate suicide victims and set up fast-track courts for paper-leaks cases



discussion' on NEET paper leak

JULY 23-24: Mr. Wangchuk ends fast at midnight; Ministers Nadda and Jitendra Singh meet CJP team at Constitution Club; protesters reiterate demand for Pradhan's resignation

JULY 25: Mr. Pradhan quits; Mr. Nadda and Mr. Singh meet CJP near the protest site to finalise an agreement. CJP calls off protest

WHEN THE ‘PESTS’ PREVAILED

Opposition calls Minister’s exit a big victory for the youth and democracy

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Opposition parties on Saturday termed the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, following widespread student protests over the NEET paper leak, a “victory for the youth” and a step towards rebuilding the country’s education system.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said, “It’s a symbolic step because he was a symbol, but it is still a big step.” However, he argued that removing one Minister would not address what he described as the deeper crisis confronting the country’s education and employment systems.

Mr. Gandhi also accused Union Home Minister Amit Shah of being “directly responsible” for the violence against the protesting students, alleging that he had authorised the use of pellet guns against them.

Congress MP from Wayanad Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said this was the day when the people started “claiming their country



Siding with students: Rahul Gandhi interacts with AISA members who took part in the hunger strike at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, on Saturday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

back”. “The youth did not bend; the government had to bend. It is a victory for the youth and students of India. I was truly happy when I heard the news. I even got a bit emotional,” she told media.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge described Mr. Pradhan’s resignation as a defeat of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s “stubbornness”. Congress General Secretary (organisation) K. C. Venu-

gopal said the Opposition had been spearheading the protest in a united fashion, while party general secretary (communication) Jairam Ramesh said the Opposition had demonstrated “rock-solid unity and solidarity” with the students.

‘Govt. had to bow down’ Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav said the resignation was a major victory for the new generation.

“The government had to

bow down,” he said.

Speaking to the media in Uttar Pradesh, Mr. Yadav said the movement had underlined the need for serious reforms in the education sector, from primary schooling to higher education. Aam Aadmi Party supremo and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal said Mr. Pradhan’s resignation was a “big win for democracy”.

The Left parties also welcomed the resignation

and demanded a comprehensive reform in the education sector.

CPI General Secretary D. Raja said the resignation was a rare moment of democratic accountability.

The CPI(M) congratulated the students and demanded, in a post on X, a comprehensive reform in the education sector, including the scrapping of the National Testing Agency (NTA) and the rollback of the National Education Policy (NEP). “[Mr. Pradhan’s] resignation is only the first step. Now the NTA has to be disbanded, and the anti-student, commercial and communal NEP 2020 has to be rolled back. Cases foisted on the protesters have to be dropped, and action has to be taken against all police personnel who brutally attacked our students,” CPI(M) General Secretary M.A. Baby said.

Deepankar Bhattacharya of the CPI(ML) said the resignation was “the only sensible thing” Mr. Pradhan had done “...even though you have not shown the minimum courage and honesty to admit that your resignation has been ordered by the youth of India,” he said.

Jantar Mantar breaks into songs, dance, and slogans marking movement’s win

Nikhil M. Babu
NEW DELHI

Around 2.25 p.m., as soon as the news of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation broke, Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) movement, cried jubilantly.

He then grabbed a microphone, walked to the front of the stage and addressed the thousands gathered at the protest venue in Jantar Mantar, New Delhi, “We have done it.”

With his fists clenched and raised in the air, he declared, “Dharmendra Pradhan has resigned. It was said that resignations do not happen in this government. Even the world will bow if there is a person to make it happen.”

The protest site erupted in celebration. Protesters hugged one another, broke into tears, and danced to patriotic Bollywood songs as chants of victory echoed through the crowd.

Slogans like “*Haar gaye, haar gaye, Tanashah haar gaye* (the dictator has been defeated)” reverberated across the venue.

For many students, who had spent days braving rain, heat, and sleeping on roads while demanding accountability from the government, the announcement was more than just a political development. It was an emotional affirmation that their voices had finally been heard.

Despite the resignation,



Scenes at the capital: Protesters celebrating at Jantar Mantar, New Delhi, on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

which was one of the major demands of the protesters, the crowd at Jantar Mantar continued to swell as people wanted to celebrate the “historic victory”.

Music and melody Dozens crowded around the main stage for selfies, while long queues snaked outside the venue as thousands poured into the area.

Fiery slogans “*Inquilab Zindabad*” and “*Bharat Mata ki Jai*” filled the air. Some also chanted “*Jang abhi bhi jaari hai, E20 ki baari hai* (the fight is not over, E20 is the next target)” – even as organisers appealed to the crowd to remain peaceful.

People sang along to A.R. Rahman’s ‘Vande Mataram’ being played from the stage, while Mr. Dipke waved the National Flag. Song ‘Chak De! India’ was also played.

Many distributed Melody chocolates, in an appa-

rent reference to Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifting the confectionery to the Italian Prime Minister earlier this year. Mr. Dipke, who had been unwell, soon left the area.

At around 6 p.m., CJP spokespersons Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das returned after meeting Union Ministers and announced that “we have won”, triggering another round of applause.

About half an hour later, Mr. Ranka urged the people to disperse peacefully as the protest had been called off. “We will meet you soon,” he said, as both left the venue. As some people began to leave, hundreds more kept arriving, forcing volunteers to close the entrances.

By 8:30 p.m., workers had begun dismantling the main stage. But people still climbed onto it to click selfies, amid chants of “Vande Mataram” and the fluttering of National Flags.

With tears of relief, Dipke’s parents recall son’s protest journey

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

When CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke’s parents came to know that Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had resigned and that the government had accepted the demands of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), they did not know what to say. They stood without words, tears rolling down their eyes.

“These are tears of joy and relief,” Anita Dipke told reporters gathered at the family’s home in Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar as news of the withdrawal of the protest came in. Relatives and neighbours had gathered at the Dipke residence, with sweets and firecrackers.

Abhijeet Dipke, who lead the protests in Delhi, is the only child of Ms. Anita and Bhagwanrao Dipke.

“Ink was thrown on him. He was slapped. He had to bear so much! We are very happy today. His hard work has finally paid off. His honesty has been rewarded. We were under stress for the last two-and-a-half months,” Ms. Dipke told reporters.

Had Mr. Pradhan not resigned, there was uncertainty over the direction the agitation would have taken, Mr. Bhagwanrao said. “There was a lot of anger in the hearts of the



Abhijeet Dipke

students, and their parents too,” he added.

He recollected the difficult time the family had to endure in the past weeks.

“Abhijeet was termed a terrorist, he was beaten up. He was accused of being funded by foreign countries. We faced tremendous pressure when he returned from the U.S. But, he has finally succeeded. Had he been around today, I would have hugged him.”

After finding the live coverage of the protest too stressful, the Dipke family had stopped watching TV. When asked how they had learnt of the recent developments, Mr. Bhagwanrao said that he had received a call from a friend, after which he had searched for the news on YouTube.

Meanwhile, his family informed that Mr. Abhijeet is undergoing treatment for typhoid.

Bihar bandh turns violent; police open fire in Siwan, injuring three protesters

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Police in Bihar’s Siwan opened fire on protesters on Saturday as the Bihar bandh, called by the All India Students’ Association (AISA) to protest the NEET paper leak, turned violent in several parts of the State, with incidents of stone pelting and vandalism.

By the time Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned in Delhi, the damage had already been done in Bihar. Siwan police fired 10 rounds, injuring at least three protesters with their bullets. Police initially used tear gas and mild force to disperse the crowd but later opened fire as protesters continued throwing stones at security personnel. Siwan Superintendent of Police Puran Jha and several other police officers were injured in the stone pelting.

The pelting took place in several districts, including Saran, Sitamarhi, Bhagalpur, Aurangabad, West Champaran, Lakhisarai, and Patna. Police jeeps were set on fire in Chapra and Sitamarhi.

In Patna, a police jeep was overturned by the protesters, followed by heavy stone pelting near



Tensions spill over: Protesters overturn a police vehicle during the ‘Bihar Bandh’ against NEET paper leaks, in Patna on Saturday. ANI

Gandhi Maidan. A large number of students gathered near Gandhi Maidan and climbed a mobile tower near Ramghulam Chowk, where Janshakti Janata Dal (JJD) president Tej Pratap Yadav was also seen waving the tricolour.

‘Arrogance of power’ Around 70,000 police jawans were deployed across the State and their leaves were cancelled for the deputation. Schools were closed in several districts, including Patna and Aurangabad.

Along with the local police, personnel from the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), Border Security Force (BSF), Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB), and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) were deployed to control the crowd.

The Opposition Rashtri-

ya Janata Dal (RJD) slammed the State government for opening fire at the protesters. “Bihar police fired bullets at protesters in Siwan! Tear gas shells can still be understood, but why were bullets fired? [Bihar Chief Minister] Samrat Choudhary has gone mad with the arrogance of power,” the RJD said in a post on X.

The Leader of Opposition in the State Assembly, Tejashwi Yadav, also posted a video message on X, saying, “...The police fired bullets on the innocent students who were protesting. Action should be taken against the guilty officials.”

Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) State Secretary Kunal said the Bihar Bandh had once again proved the voices of protesting students and youth cannot be suppressed.

CJP to follow up on education reform charter after 4 weeks

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Saturday said it would follow up in about four weeks on its five-point demand charter for broader education and examination reforms, with the Union government agreeing to deliberate on the proposals and hold further discussions.

A third round of negotiations was held between CJP representatives and Union Ministers Jitendra Singh and J.P. Nadda at the Constitution Club of India. Both sides jointly addressed the media after the meeting. Mr. Nadda said all the demands had been accepted. Subsequently, CJP’s Saurav Das said: “On that note, the Cockroach Janta Party declares that we withdraw the agitation in good faith and understanding that the agreed-upon terms will be executed within the agreed-upon time period.” CJP represen-

tative Ashutosh Ranka then urged the protesters in the national capital to return home immediately.

The CJP had made three demands: resignation of Mr. Pradhan; compensation to the families of deceased students; and scrapping of cases against protesters and organisers in Delhi and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)/National Democratic Alliance (NDA)-ruled States.

During the second meeting on Friday, they also submitted the five-point charter.

Stating that deep sympathies of the government were with the aggrieved families, Mr. Nadda said maximum possible honourable compensation as per the rules and regulations would be given to them. “The government expressed condolences to the families of the students who lost their lives and assured them of the highest possible compensation as per the rules,” he said.

Sharad Pawar, Thackeray cousins cheer nation’s youth

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Nationalist Congress Party-SP president Sharad Pawar on Saturday said that his advice to Prime Minister Narendra Modi to hold talks with the protesting youth “may have been taken note of”, adding that democracy in the country was witnessing a revival.

Meanwhile, the Thackeray cousins, Uddhav and Raj congratulated the protesting youth and said that they had rid the country of fear.

Shiv Sena UBT chief Uddhav Thackeray, addressing a joint press conference with his cousin and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief Raj Thackeray in Mumbai, said the protests had shown that “dictatorship cannot be imposed on the country.”

“The youth have brought the country out of an atmosphere of fear. A cockroach has made a dictator bow,” he added.

INBRIEF



Amarnath Yatra resumes in J&K amid inclement weather

Amid the inclement weather, the Amarnath Yatra resumed from the Baltal Axis in central Kashmir on Saturday after a six-day halt. The Yatra also resumed at the Mata Vaishno Devi temple in Jammu. Officials said a batch of 6,269 pilgrims arrived at the Baltal base camp in Kashmir in a convoy of 223 vehicles. “Due to the recent rains, urgent repair and maintenance works are required to be carried out on the Pahalgam Axis of Shri Amarnathji Yatra. The Yatra shall continue through the Baltal Axis, for which adequate arrangements have been put in place to ensure a smooth and safe pilgrimage,” Divisional Commissioner of Kashmir, Anshul Garg, said.

Punjab police secure fugitive gangster’s deportation

Punjab’s Anti-Gangster Task Force, in coordination with the central agencies, has successfully secured the deportation of a fugitive gangster from Jakarta after a six-month-long manhunt, police said on Saturday. DGP Gaurav Yadav said Jobanjit Singh is wanted in multiple heinous criminal cases, including murder, attempt to murder, Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act and Arms Act offences. “The operation marks the successful culmination of Operation Nomad Hunt, a six-month-long intelligence-led international manhunt involving sustained surveillance,” Mr. Yadav said on X. PTI

Rajasthan on alert after deaths linked to Chandipura virus

Rajasthan’s health department has intensified surveillance and stepped up vector-control measures in Dungarpur, Sirohi and adjoining areas after reports confirmed that two girls from the state, who died while undergoing treatment in Gujarat, had tested positive for the Chandipura virus (CHPV). The deceased include a six-year-old girl from Ratanpura village in Dungarpur district and a two-year-old girl from Sirohi district. Chandipura virus is an emerging vector-borne pathogen that primarily affects children aged below 15. It causes fever, flu-like symptoms and acute encephalitis, and is transmitted by vectors such as mosquitoes, ticks and sandflies. PTI

Assam police arrest 3 linked to Pak.-based terror network

The Assam police have unearthed a terror module linked to Pakistan-based Shahzad Bhatti network and arrested three alleged operatives in the State, an official said on Saturday. The official said the Special Task Force (STF) conducted a coordinated operation on Friday with assistance from the district police of Dhubri, Chirang, and Barpeta. STF Senior Superintendent of Police Pranab Kumar Pegu said, “The Pakistan-based terrorist-criminal network is allegedly involved in recruitment, online radicalisation, espionage, illegal procurement of arms, establishment of sleeper cells and facilitation of terrorist activities in different parts of the country.” PTI

SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to yesterday’s Sudoku

7	5	9	1	2	8	3	6	4
6	8	4	5	7	3	9	2	1
1	3	2	4	9	6	5	7	8
2	9	1	6	8	7	4	5	3
8	6	3	2	4	5	7	1	9
4	7	5	9	3	1	6	8	2
3	2	6	8	5	9	1	4	7
9	1	8	7	6	4	2	3	5
5	4	7	3	1	2	8	9	6

Urban food habits rewriting gut microbiome in India, says study

Study finds links between urban diets and gut microbiomes that could be reason behind rising diabetes rates in India; as of 2024, India has about 89.8 million adults living with diabetes, even as an estimated 43% of cases currently go undiagnosed

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Bacteria in the human gut, and not just genes, may help explain why urbanising Indians face rising rates of diabetes, obesity and hypertension. This is from a three-year study that has produced what its authors describe as the first reference database of the gut microbiome across South Asia.

The study, published in the peer-reviewed *Gut Microbes*, sampled 575 adults from 10 communities across India and Sri Lanka and profiled their gut bacteria through gene. Niraj Rai of the Birbal Sahni Institute of Palaeosciences, Lucknow, who led the work with Maanasa Raghavan of the University of Chicago, said India offered a rare natural experiment. “India is the only country where you can still find a rural versus urban” population that shares ancestry



Access to processed food is the reason behind differences in gut bacteria of city dwellers and their rural relatives, says study. REUTERS

but lives in very different food environments, he said.

India has an estimated 89.8 million adults living with diabetes as of 2024, according to the International Diabetes Federation’s latest data. This is the second-largest burden in the world after China, and roughly one in every seven adults with the disease globally.

The federation projects India’s total will climb about 75% to reach 156.7

million by 2050, even as an estimated 43% of cases currently go undiagnosed. Worldwide, 589 million adults are estimated to have diabetes. The disease’s steep rise in India has been driven in large part by rapid urbanisation and dietary change – the very transition this study set out to read in the gut.

The researchers designed their study by pairing each remote, forest-dwelling or early-agriculturalist community with

relatives who had migrated to towns and cities with access to processed food – “pizza, chowmein, coke,” in Mr. Rai’s description. Because both groups share genetic ancestry, verified by genome sequencing, he argued that differences in their microbiomes must stem from environment rather than genes.

Sri Lanka’s Vedda, among the region’s oldest hunter-gatherer settlers, were included because they remain genetically South Asian while retaining a foraging lifestyle that Mr. Rai said approximates an “ancient gut signature.”

Urban-rural bacteria

The clearest example of environment reshaping the same genetics is *Megamonas*, a bacterium the study found consistently more abundant in urban individuals than in their rural kin. Megamonas has been linked worldwide to obesity, hypertension and raised blood glucose. “We

are reporting for the first time that Megamonas are thriving because of change in diet,” Mr. Rai said.

Running the other way is *Holdemanella*, associated with fibre intake and glucose tolerance, prevalent in South Asia but apparently lost with urbanisation – except in Kerala, Mr. Rai noted, where communities largely kept traditional diets even after migrating.

Mr. Rai framed urbanisation as a matter of food processing rather than meat-eating. In the north-east, he said, rural and urban communities both eat meat; the urban difference is the biscuit, soft drink, and occasional pizza.

The project is now moving to a functional phase. Mr. Rai’s team has begun metabolomics – profiling the molecules these bacteria produce – to connect specific microbes to specific diseases. By year’s end, he expects roughly 1,000 samples.

Five killed as car plunges into dam in MP’s Rajgarh

The Hindu Bureau
BHOPAL

Five people were killed in Madhya Pradesh’s Rajgarh district on Saturday after a car they were travelling in skidded off the road and plunged into a small dam reservoir, police said.

According to the police, the incident took place around 12 p.m. near Bhilkhedi junction on the border of Pachore and Khujner police stations when the car lost control while approaching a culvert and fell into the reservoir.

Pachore police station in-charge Shakuntala Bamniya told *The Hindu* that all five men hailed from neighbouring Shajapur district and were travelling to a famous temple in Khujner.

Ms. Bamniya said that as per preliminary investigation, the car may have fallen off the road while trying to avoid an animal on the road or a vehicle coming from the opposite direction.

“The car also flipped before plunging into the 10-12 feet deep water,” she said.

Gujarat floods: toll rises to 35 as floodwaters recede; damage surveys begin

Abhinav Deshpande
AHMEDABAD



Truck drivers wade through a flooded road after their vehicles got stuck following heavy rainfall in Ahmedabad on Saturday. PTI

The death toll from rain-related incidents in Gujarat has risen to 35 over the past two days, with authorities recovering bodies after floodwaters receded and rescue operations concluded, Relief Commissioner Gaurang Makwana said on Saturday.

Most of the fatalities occurred due to drowning or people being swept away by strong currents. Of the total deaths, 29 were reported from the worst-affected districts of Navsari and Valsad.

With rainfall easing across the State, the administration has shifted its focus to post-flood restoration. Authorities have begun assessing damage to crops, houses and public infrastructure, besides undertaking cleaning drives and pesticide spraying to prevent the spread of water-borne diseases.

More than 7,000 people

were rescued during the recent spell of heavy rain, with the highest number of rescue operations carried out in Navsari and Surat districts. Over 42,000 residents were relocated to safer places, Mr. Makwana said.

The State deployed 18 teams of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and 32 teams of the State Disaster Response Force, supported by the Indian Army, Coast Guard and local volunteers.

Valsad District Collector Nitin Sangwan said damage assessment surveys

had begun. Financial assistance for affected residents, including compensation for wage losses of up to three days, damaged household items, and livestock deaths, will be disbursed from Monday.

Red alert

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued a red alert on Saturday for Banaskantha, Patan, Surendranagar, Mehsana, Kheda, Aravalli and Sabarkantha districts, while an orange alert has been forecast for some of these districts on Sunday.

Enemy intentions remain unchanged, proxy war still a challenge, says Rajnath

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR



Rajnath Singh presents a memento to a relative of a martyr during Vijay Diwas celebrations at the Kargil War Memorial on Saturday. PTI

Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, who toured Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh’s Drass on Saturday, said the intentions of the enemies have not changed and the proxy war still remains a security challenge in the region.

Without naming Pakistan, Mr. Singh, while speaking at Shaurya Bhoj in Drass, said, “As we celebrate the Kargil war victory, we have to remind ourselves of the challenges. The intention of our enemy remains the same. Proxy war is still used as a tactic. Our Army is ready to foil these nefarious designs.”

The Defence Minister arrived in Srinagar on Saturday morning on a two-day tour of the region. He was received by J&K Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha. Officials said they discussed the current security situation in J&K, especially

in the wake of the Anantnag attack that left one policeman dead three days ago.

Later, Mr. Singh visited the war memorial at Ladakh’s Drass on the eve of 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas. He paid tributes to the soldiers who laid down their lives in the line of duty in the 1999 Kargil War, as he attended the ‘Shaurya Sandhya’.

“It’s these sacrifices that make people of India feel safe. When oxygen levels dropped in 1999, the guns of our soldiers did not fall

silent till the Tricolour was unfurled as a mark of victory,” said Mr. Singh.

Ten families of Kargil War bravehearts were also felicitated on the occasion. Commemorative events were held at ‘Yudh Sansmaran’ at Lamochen View Point, where Kargil War veterans and families of fallen soldiers remembered the sacrifices made during Operation Vijay.

A documentary and special presentations highlighting the valour of 40 war heroes were screened during the event.

Why are mega data centre projects facing stiff resistance?

EXPLAINER

Paul Nicodemus
Snehal Mutha

This week, people in Andhra Pradesh and Maharashtra took to the streets to oppose the proposed mega data centre projects in the States.

In A.P., after the government allotted about 601 acres of land across three locations in Visakhapatnam and Anakapalli district, Raiden Infotech India Pvt. Ltd. – a Google company – began developing a IGW AI data centre hub, with Adani Infra/Adani-ConneX as the notified development partner.

In Maharashtra, residents of Thane have been opposing Amazon’s proposed hyperscale data centre project. The ₹7,203.29-crore project spread over 53.73 acres is under construction across

the villages of Balkum Pada and Majiwada in Thane.

Reasons for opposition Citizens’ groups in Visakhapatnam have opposed the Andhra project, highlighting concerns over the strain on resources such as water and power, as well as its environmental impact. The project is coming up at three locations – Adavivaram-Mudasarlova, Tarluvada, and Rambilli.

Campaigners also cited that the Super El Niño-like weather pattern has put strain on water resources across the State.

In Thane, people have cited sketchy details, discrepancies in water usage data, lack of consultation with locals as reasons to rally against the project.

Residents represented by the citizen group ‘Wakeup Thanekar’ has demanded clarity on the water usage and a public hearing. It has sought the



Citizen groups hold a protest against proposed data centre projects in and around Visakhapatnam, along Beach Road on July 19. V. RAJU

establishment of baseline noise and air quality measurements, and a clarity on the actual benefit to locals.

The opposition from citizens was not to technology or investment but to a project that offered little in return for its costs, said Sohan Hatangadi, a campaigner in Visakhapatnam. He cited limited permanent employment and limited ancillary industry, even as the city provides

land and incentives.

President of Green Visakh, Raja Rama Mohan Roy, said the project risked the “reckless exploitation of nature”. He said the Kambalakonda Eco-Forest, and the surroundings of the Rambilli Wildlife Sanctuary faced a threat, along with the Mudasarlova reservoir, a source of drinking water for the city.

In Thane, activists are against “unplanned deve-

lopment”. “We cannot have the data centre in residential area, which are already suffering water shortage, load shedding, and other issues,” Sadhana Pradhan, convener of Wake-up Thanekar said.

The group plans to file a petition with the National Green Tribunal after the government response. It had held a meeting with the Thane municipal commissioner and representatives of Amazon. “We are disappointed as they had no answers to basic question of what will be the source of the water required for cooling,” Ms. Pradhan said.

Concerns over water

A more pressing constraint for Visakhapatnam was inadequate storage capacity, a concern that engineers had flagged internally, D. Murali Krishna, Executive Engineer, Water Supply, of the Greater Visakhapat-

nam Municipal Corporation said. He said roughly 1,000 to 2,000 acres are needed to be set aside for reservoirs, and that around 5,000 million cubic feet of storage could sustain the city for nearly six months.

Meanwhile, the Thane project will require 422 MW power and backup of 193 generators. Wakeup Thanekar group said that Amazon and the Thane corporation have given two different figures on water usage. While Amazon claimed 125 kilolitres a day per day usage, the corporation announced that it will provide 12 million litres a day of recycled sewage water.

Jatin Kothare, a resident in Balkum, said that the city is already “short of 40 MLD water”.

“So how you going to fulfil the water requirements of the data centre?” he asked.

Pet wellness becomes underlying theme as industry grows steady

Amarnath K.
CHENNAI

At Anjana’s (name changed on request) home, sitting in front of cups of freshly brewed tea, on a fine evening, her boy, Milo, is restless as it is also time for his pedigree snack. The bell rings, and the door opens to the one with a cap that bears Milo’s favourite name, the pet shop that delivers their food on a call. The delivery boy waved his hand, and Milo wagged his tail in unison. “Ten years ago, in Chennai, a door delivery of dog food was not even a possibility. But now they deliver any pet product within minutes on a call, says a Chennai-based pet parent.”

The accessibility of pet-related products and their grooming has become extensive on dedicated websites for popular pet shops and on grocery applications. Tanvi (name changed), a working pro-

fessional from Bengaluru, has a folder of applications on phone, dedicated to her cat. “A plethora of applications started appearing on app stores and became a part of my life within a few years.”

A search for a pet product on any application gives unending scrolls for you and drools for your pet. A pet parent like Ms. Anjana, who has been raising a pet for over a decade and conveniently orders food and services for their pet, would definitely trace back the beginning of abundance roughly five years ago. What would have resulted in this affluence? Is it an organic growth or a sudden boom?

The COVID ‘booster’
It was during the COVID time that the pet industry got its boost. According to data from Tracxn, the pet industry hit a high in 2021, exactly the year people were facing hurdles finan-

cially, physically and mentally due to the pandemic. In that year, 76 pet startups were reportedly launched in India, which was higher than both the preceding year (66) and the following years (50).

Pramilesh, one of the founders of Pandora Pet Mall in the Kozhikode district of Kerala, says that his team foresaw the boom, and chose the beginning of 2021 as the right time to enter the pet market. Being located near his ancestral village, knowing most of his clients personally, he could easily analyse the surge. “Most of the new pet parents were those who had to move to work-from-home mode.” For many who were confined to four walls, pets became therapeutic mentally.”

According to Dr. Soorej K., the founder of Cochin Pet Hospital, Kerala’s first private multi-specialty veterinary hospital, after the COVID outbreak, with the



Pawsome pick: A search for a pet product on any application gives unending scrolls for you and drools for your pet. G. RAMAKRISHNA

newfound affection for pets, the trend of ‘teacup breeds’ has upturned. He says that people preferred breeds like Shih Tzu and poodle dogs, and Persian cats that could be raised inside their flats .

Though this surge was witnessed in 2020, the pet industry has always been one with a steady and stable growth. “I don’t think

such a sudden spike like this again will be a good thing, as many pet parents abandoned their pets after the COVID lockdown period; thus most of the infrastructure and mechanisms that were brought in by the industry lay unused after the expeditious hike. The situation of every other industry that hit a high is almost the same.” “This in-

dustry will continue with this same stable growth as people look up to pet care irrespective of times,” he said. The IBEF data on India’s pet-care industry proves Dr. Soorej has a right prospect as it projects a seven-fold growth from a ₹30,434 crore valued industry in CY 2024 to a ₹2.1 lakh crore one in CY 2032.

A ‘wuff’ revolution
Dr. Soorej said there was a change in people’s attitude towards dogs when they were restricted within homes. Sarah Cherian, a business developer with Zoho, said she wanted a companion to push through the one year that she worked from home during COVID.

“A conventional image of dogs was of a ferocious one that takes care of your home. But the work-from-home culture brought about a change in people’s attitude.” A “wuff” is what people liked more than a

shuddering growl that dogs stood for.

With great cuteness comes great spending. Exotic breeds of dogs and cats are ardent fans of exotic food. “My cat would give you a deadly stare if you go with a bowl of ‘Drools’. On a sniff of it, her look tells you ‘no, this is not my food.” Ms. Tanvi talks about her Persian cat, Bella. From the data by IBEF, pet food contributes to the largest share of the industry, which was valued at ₹4,000 crore in CY 2024. According to Euromonitor, the food market of the country is expected to hit ₹10,000 crore by CY 2028.

Abundance to homeless
An amateur dog breeder, Ranjith K.J. has seen people buying and increasingly raising “stud dogs” during the COVID lockdown, to benefit the increasing demand for puppies.

“After the demand hit a low, people started to so-

mehow avoid the ‘stock’ that they had.” Dr. Sooraj has seen people selling Shih Tzu puppies for ₹5,000, which were, at times during lockdown, being sold for as much as ₹60,000.

A tremendous trend of pet boarding and pet adoption surfaced during this period. Dogs of Madras, a pet adoption service based out of Chennai, talks about witnessing a striking hike in dog adoption rates five years ago.

Most of them were due to the same reason Mr. Pramilesh mentioned. “Around 2024-2025, we have seen a lot of re-homing requests,” team Dogs of Madras says. It was the time when they hosted pet adoption drives regularly. Relocation to work, according to the team, was one of the biggest reasons people give up their pets. They lose the once-achieved interest in taking responsibility for a pet.

INBRIEF



ONGC starts drilling first deepwater well in Mahanadi

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) on Saturday commenced drilling its first deepwater exploratory well in the Mahanadi offshore basin, marking the start of an ambitious campaign to tap India’s deep and ultra-deepwater hydrocarbon resources. ONGC spudded exploratory well, MN-DW18-1-H-D under the government’s Samudra Manthan mission, the firm said in a statement. The well is being drilled around 23 nautical miles from the Konark discovery off the Odisha coast, building on ONGC’s recent Utkal and Konark discoveries. PTI

PhonePe’s FY26 revenue grows to ₹7,920 crore

Demonstrating strong top-line momentum, PhonePe’s consolidated revenue from operations rose to ₹7,920 crore in FY26, according to regulatory filings with the Registrar of Companies (RoC). This represents a top-line expansion of ₹815 crore, marking an 11.47% increase compared with the previous fiscal year. As the government is yet to release the UPI Digital Incentive (DI) funds for FY26 to the industry, the revenue associated with DI has not been recognized in FY26. This portion of the FY26-related DI revenue is expected to accrue in PhonePe’s FY27 financials. On a normalised operational basis, PhonePe’s net loss stood at ₹1,377 crore. PTI

U.S. banking platform Bluevine eyes Indian businesses

Bluevine, a U.S.-based digital business banking platform focused on small businesses, is increasingly eyeing a growing number of Indian firms seeking to set up establishments in the U.S. as part of their expansion strategy. “The owners, operators and entrepreneurs who generate revenue in the U.S., if they have a U.S. entity, by definition, need to open a U.S. bank account, which represents an opportunity for us”, said Aditya Narula, General Manager; India and General Manager of Global Lending & Credit, Bluevine. Bluevine said it expects international markets to contribute 20% of its overall revenue over the next two to three years.

BNP Paribas Cardif to acquire 26% stake in Indiafirst Life

French insurer BNP Paribas Cardif on Friday announced that it will be acquiring a 26% stake in Indiafirst Life for an undisclosed sum from private equity major Warburg Pincus. Post-deal, Bank of Baroda will own 65% of the company, Union Bank of India will be at 9%, while the rest will be with BNP Paribas Cardif. Shareholders are aiming to accelerate the growth of the 12th largest private life insurance company through Bank of Baroda’s branch network, the company’s own multi-channel distribution strength and BNP Paribas Cardif’s global bancassurance expertise, product innovation and insurance capabilities, as per an official statement. PTI

Submit papers promptly or face ex-parte orders: IRDAI

All information pertaining to the complaint must be submitted in one-go to help Ombudsmen decide the case within 90 days, regulatory body tells insurers, warns against non-compliance

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD



IRDAI directed insurers to clear all pending requests for SCNs.

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has set timelines for insurers to submit documents related to complaints before the Insurance Ombudsmen and warned that non-compliance could result in ex-parte orders.

The regulator has directed all the insurers, except reinsurers, to submit the self-contained note (SCN), along with all supporting documents, within seven days of receiving a notice from Insurance Ombudsmen concerned.

Any additional information or documents sought by Ombudsmen must be furnished within three days of the notice.

All the required information and relevant documents should be submitted in “one-go” rather than in a

piece-meal manner, IRDAI said in a circular.

It also directed insurers to clear all pending requests for SCNs, additional information and supporting documents from the offices of Ombudsman within 30 days of the circular.

Failure to comply will result in Insurance Ombudsman concerned proceeding with the matter ex parte, based on the information available on record, without further delay, the regulator said.

In support, it cited Rule 17(4) of the Insurance Ombudsman Rules that require Ombudsmen to finalise findings and pass awards within three

months of receiving all required information from the complainant.

Executive Director R.K.Sharma said IRDAI had noted with concern the inordinate delays by insurers in submitting SCNs, supporting documents and additional information sought by Ombudsmen.

Besides raising this, the Insurance Ombudsmen, during a recent orientation programme, had also pointed out that insurers often submit documents in a piecemeal fashion and after significant delays. Such an approach in turn to lead to delay in disposal of the complaints filed by policyholders/beneficiaries.

India set to roll out common customer ID for banks, insurers

Reuters
MUMBAI

Indian banks and insurers will launch a common customer identification system in August, with asset managers joining later, two regulatory sources and industry executives told Reuters, allowing customers to access financial products without separately submitting identification documents.

The new system, known as Central Know-Your-Customer 2.0 (CKYC), will only require the customer’s consent for these institutions to fetch data stored at a central registry when opening an account or updating their details.

India has spent more than a decade trying to create a system similar to those in countries such as Singapore and several European nations, where digital identity frameworks allow customers to access multiple financial products through a common verification process.

It will also help combat fraud through easier monitoring, the regulatory sources said.

Capital markets firms, including mutual funds and brokerages, are expected to be able to use it later this year as regulators work through sector-specific requirements, they

Capital markets firms, including MFs, are expected to be able to use it later this year

said. The sources declined to be identified as they are not authorised to speak to the media. The Reserve Bank of India, the Securities and Exchange Board of India and the insurance regulator, all of whom are jointly executing the project, did not answer Reuters emails immediately.

The move comes as India seeks to deepen participation in financial products after having largely achieved basic financial inclusion. About 89% of adults owned bank accounts in 2024, as per World Bank data, but ownership in mutual funds, insurance and pensions remains comparatively low, regulatory data showed.

While India already has a central registry containing about 1.2 billion customer records, it is not widely used due to concerns about the quality of data, with duplication and missing details.

With the RBI not accepting records sourced from the registry, investors had to file the same documents to access other financial products.

OFFICE OF THE MUNICIPAL COUNCIL BEAWAR
Tel. No. 01462-258665 Email Addr :- npbeawar@gmail.com
Ret No: NPB/Garage/2026-27/5194 Date: 22.07.2026

NOTICE INVITING BID
Online Bids are invited on E-Procurement Portal Rajasthan up to 13.08.2026 till 11:00 AM for E-Rate Contract regarding Collection, Loading, Transportation of Municipal Solid Waste from Zone No. 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 (All 05 Zones) and Unloading at Solid Waste Processing Facility, Badi Ghati, Beawar. Estimated Cost for each Zone is 35.00 Lakh Rupees. Details of bid are available on E-Procurement Portal Rajasthan and SPPP Portal Rajasthan. Tender forms and documents are to be downloaded from the E-Procurement Portal Rajasthan or SPPP Portal Rajasthan and used by the bidders. Bids will be opened on 13.08.2026 after 03:00 PM.
NIB - DLB2627A4579
UBN ZONE 01: DLB2627SLOB10929
UBN ZONE 02: DLB2627SLOB10931
UBN ZONE 03: DLB2627SLOB10933
UBN ZONE 04: DLB2627SLOB10935
UBN ZONE 05: DLB2627SLOB10937
Raj.Samwad/C/26/7565
Commissioner
Municipal Council Beawar

बीकानेर नगर निगम
नगर निगम मार्ग, बीकानेर (राजस्थान) फ़ैक्स :- 0151-2226906, फ़ोन :- 0151-2226902, 0151-2226905
E-Mail Address :- nagarnigambikaner@gmail.com, Web Site :- www.bikanernmc.org
Sr.No./SBM_EVC Station/2026-27/6858 Date: 21.07.2026

NOTICE INVITING BIDS
NIB No. 52/2026-27 Date (UBN Number DLB2627SLOB10921)
Online bids are invited electronically on behalf of the Municipal Corporation Bikaner for the work Procurement of Service For "Request for Proposal (RFP) for "DEVELOPMENT OF EVC STATION AT URBAN AREA IN BIKANER MUNICIPAL CORPORATION- CIRCLE-4", from enlisted /eligible bidders of appropriate class of the department organization.
The complete Bidding Document may be seen or downloaded from the website of State Public Procurement Portal <http://sppp.rajabhaskar.gov.in>, e-procurement portal <http://eproc.rajabhaskar.gov.in> and <https://bikanernmc.org/>.
Tender Cost :- 250.00 Lacs
Raj.Samwad/C/26/7576
Commissioner
Bikaner Municipal Corporation

फ्लुइड कंट्रोल रिसर्च इंस्टीट्यूट
FLUID CONTROL RESEARCH INSTITUTE
भारत सरकार, भारी उद्योग मंत्रालय के अधीन
(Under Govt. of India, Ministry of Heavy Industries)
अधिसूचना सं./Notification No. FCRI/P&A/2026-27/Scientific Staff-001/RE-JRE 22.07.2026

अनुसंधान अभियंता और कनिष्ठ अनुसंधान अभियंता पदों के लिए सीधी भर्ती
DIRECT RECRUITMENT FOR RESEARCH ENGINEERS & JUNIOR RESEARCH ENGINEERS
भारतीय नागरिकों से निम्नलिखित पदों के लिए आवेदन आमंत्रित करते हैं। Applications are invited from Indian Nationals for below posts:

पद एवं वेतन Post & Pay	शैक्षिक और अनुभव मानदंड* Educational & Experience Criteria*
अनुसंधान अभियंता Research Engineer वेतन स्तर / Pay Level 10 (₹.56100 - 177500)	मैकेनिकल इंजीनियरिंग में स्नातक/स्नातकोत्तर डिग्री Graduate / Post Graduate in Mechanical Engineering"
कनिष्ठ अनुसंधान अभियंता Junior Research Engineer वेतन स्तर / Pay Level 8 (₹.47600 - 151100)	मैकेनिकल/सिविल/इलेक्ट्रिकल/इंस्ट्रुमेंटेशन इंजीनियरिंग में स्नातक Graduate degree in Mechanical / Civil / Electrical / Instrumentation Engineering"

ऑनलाइन आवेदन तिथि / Start date of Online Applications: 24.07.2026.
अंतिम तिथि / Closing date: 24.08.2026.
इच्छुक उम्मीदवार आवेदन प्रक्रिया, विशेषता और प्रारंभिक अनुभव सहित पूरी जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट www.fcridia.com/career देखें । Interested candidates are advised to visit www.fcridia.com/career for full details including application criteria and information on how to apply.

राज ऋषि मर्तुहरि मत्स्य विश्वविद्यालय, अलवर
क्रमांक - राजनविप्र/अल/रा.प्र./2026/9996 दिनांक - 21/07/2026

E-Bid Inviting Notice
(NIB No. 02/2026-27)
Bids for the selection of a service provider for the examination work in Raj Rishi Bhartihari Matsya University at Haldina campus, alwar are invited from interested bidders upto time 5:00 pm dated 10-08-2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal <http://eproc.rajabhaskar.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in> of the state and www.rbmuniw.ac.in. The approximate value of the procurement is 12.00 crore.
UBN No. - MUA2627SLR00002, NIB No. - MUA2627A0002
Raj.Samwad/C/26/7540
Registrar

Kalyan Singh Super Specialty Cancer Institute
C.G. City, Sultanpur Road, Lucknow-226002
(An Autonomous Institute of the Govt. of Uttar Pradesh)
Website: <https://cancerinstitute.edu.in> Email: jddmm.ssciih@gmail.com

TENDER NOTICE
On-line offers are invited through Custom bids on GeM portal. The GEM bid Nos. are given herewith;

- GEM/2026/B/7807690 dated: 25.07.2026 for the item - **Automated Component Preparation Machine**
- GEM/2026/B/7808731 dated: 25-07-2026 for the item - **Enteral Feeding Pump**
- GEM/2026/B/7808416 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item-3 **Pin Head Fixation Machine with Accessory**
- GEM/2026/B/7807935 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item-Micro **Bipolar Cautery Forceps**
- GEM/2026/B/7807835 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item- **Craniotomy Set**
- GEM/2026/B/7807890 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item- **Interooperative Portable Doppler System**
- GEM/2026/B/7809327 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item- **Automated Secretion Management System for Ventilated Patients (PAC item)**
- GEM/2026/B/7810200 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item- **OT Table for Robotic Surgery (PAC item)**
- GEM/2026/B/7810442 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item- **Surgical Workstation (PAC item)**
- GEM/2026/B/7810328 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item- **High End EV Workstation(PAC item)**
- GEM/2026/B/7810523 dated: 23.07.2026 for the item- **Patient Mobilizer (PAC item)**

Offers are invited from Original Equipment Manufacture/Direct Importers/Authorized Distributors (declared by principal firm only) for the supply & installation of **aforementioned Equipment**.
Bidders should submit their Representation only on GeM Portal regarding Equipment within time frame provided by GeM. The Vendors are required to submit their offers on GeM portal only in two bids system i.e. Technical and Financial bid as per norms of GeM Portal with terms and conditions as mentioned against bidding documents.

For more detailed information you may please visit the Gem portal www.gem.gov.in or our website <https://cancerinstitute.edu.in>, for reference only.
The Director reserves the right to accept or reject any tender in part or full without assigning any reason thereof.
Advt No. KSSSCI/Tender -09/2026-27
DIRECTOR

A lost Himalayan people emerges from a Ladakh cave

A study published recently in *Science Advances* has reported genome-wide data from 10 individuals recovered from a cave in Kargil. Radiocarbon dating places them at roughly 1,500 years before the present. One half were best proxied by present-day North Indians; the others were genetically closer to ancient Tibetans. Chromosome segments date that union to about 2,800 years ago, a

However, a second team reached the cave first. In a preprint posted in January,

David Reich, professor of genetics at Harvard Medical School and a corresponding author on the *Science Advances* paper,

Both papers agreed on the genetic identities of the cave people as well as that their genes contained a third 'ingredient' – in the form of a population from Inner Asia. Since nobody has yet excavated the exact ancient Tibetan population that mixed into Ladakh, the Harvard-led team reached for a Bronze Age group from Xinjiang.

The papers also differ on when the peoples mixed: 2,800 years ago or 2,100-2,500 years ago. The preprint – Rai said it would appear in the next issue of *Science Advances* – called its result the oldest evidence yet of ancestral North Indian ancestry. This component underlies

Dr. Mushrif-Tripathy said, however, that the community lived astride a trade route, where admixture could have been continuous.

India's rice fields rank among world's top methane sources

“Most previous studies have focused on a single greenhouse gas, a specific management practice or a particular region,” Hanqin Tian, co-author of the study and director and institute professor, Department of Earth and Environmental Sciences, Boston College, the U.S., said. “Our study provides a much more comprehensive assessment by integrating a global meta-analysis of more than 1,200 field experiments, process-based ecosystem modelling, and artificial intelligence approaches to quantify GHG emissions from rice cultivation worldwide.”

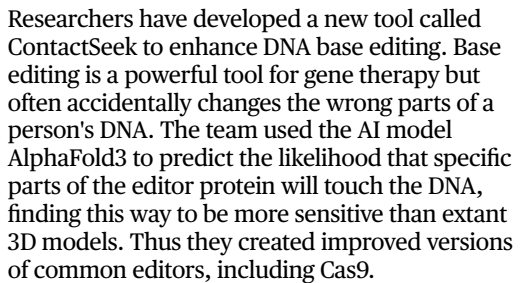
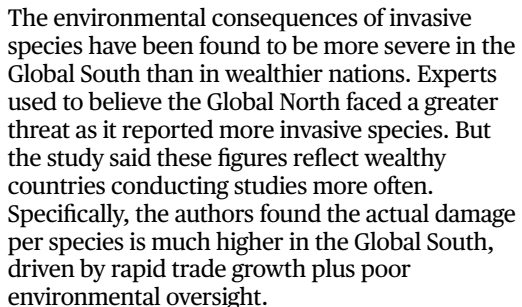
The study also projected that between 2031 and 2050, annual emissions will increase by a quarter, fuelled by global warming, erratic rainfall, and the intense use of agricultural inputs. Irrigated paddy fields

However, the methods don't address the emission reduction potentials varying widely between States. Apart from demonstrations of alternatives across districts under NICRA, several national and State-level policies and incentives are designed to encourage farmers to adopt the alternative methods. However,

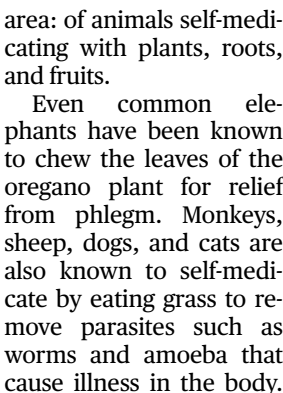
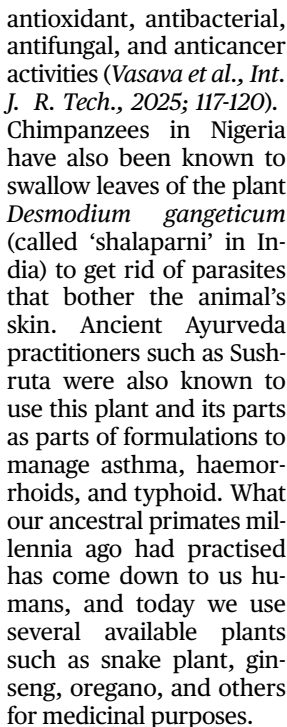
“Using a multi-pronged approach, which includes increasing soil organic carbon, understanding the hydrology and aligned irrigation systems, agricultural inputs, residue management protocols, soil microbes and farmer preferences, we are working on

(Sharmila Vaidyanathan is an independent journalist from Bengaluru)

Using the radial velocity method, astronomers have found a large body orbiting a brown dwarf CD-35 2722 B, which orbits a star. It is estimated to be 90% as massive as Jupiter and orbiting the brown dwarf every 170 days on an oval path. The find is a milestone in the search for moons outside the solar system and challenges current ideas: the object is so large it blurs the line between a moon and a planet.



Zoopharmacognosy — when animals medicate themselves



There is also evidence that monkeys share with us humans the ability to track auditory regularities. In other words they also possess a faculty to appreciate music. Y. Ayala et al., in 2017 (*Scientific Reports* 7, 16687), pointed out that the rhesus monkeys res-

We should keep these details in mind when exposing animals to stressful environments like shelters and veterinary clinics, where the right kind of music can visibly calm anxious animals. As for friends with pet dogs: play music and let your dog enjoy it too!

dbala@lvypei.org

Follow the chemistry

the lighter isotope of carbon (carbon-12) during photosynthesis – and fossil fuels are highly enriched in carbon-12 relative to carbon of inorganic origins. Fossil fuels are never from dinosaurs. In 1930, the Sinclair Oil Corporation used a dinosaur in a marketing campaign to emphasise the ancient and natural qualities of its oil. They also sponsored a dinosaur exhibit at the 1933 Chicago World's Fair. Further, the word 'fossil' originally meant anything dug up from the ground, and was used in the 1700s to refer to coal or oil deposits.

Scientists identified fossil fuels to be the remains of ancient life using physical and chemical evidence. Early on, some scientists thought oil was a mineral 'sweated' out of the earth's interior. But in the 16th century, naturalists found imprints of leaves and tree trunks inside coal seams, suggesting that coal is compressed plant matter. Modern chemists also found molecules in crude oil that are only produced by living organisms, such as hopanoids and steranes. Finally, plants prefer to use

Readers may send their questions / answers to science@thehindu.co.in

PROFILES

Masters of the midfield

Spanish football team

With aggressive defence and precise attack, La Roja’s young champions blended the country’s timeless philosophy of control with a more direct, adaptable style to win a second football World Cup

Anirudh Velamuri

In 2010, Spain reached the pinnacle of international football with a squad overflowing with established stars. A generation of world-class players combined technical brilliance, tactical intelligence and an unwavering belief in the power of possession to secure the nation’s first FIFA World Cup title. The team that won its maiden World Cup title also lifted the European Championship before and after it. That squad set a benchmark for Spanish, nay, world football. For years, every side was forced to live in the shadows of that generation.

Comparisons became inevitable and only intensified after Spain’s group-stage exit in 2014 and a pair of Round of 16 exits at the 2018 and 2022 World Cups. Every edition ended with the same question: Was Spain trying too hard to recreate the past? In 2026, the answer finally arrived in the form of another World Cup-winning side that respected its history without becoming trapped by it. This group, like that all-conquering generation, still valued technique above chaos and considered the ball an ally rather than something to be surrendered.

But they were also more open to embracing life beyond tiki-taka. They defended with greater aggression, attacked more directly when required and, above all, seamlessly married beautiful football with “ugly” decisions. They showed immense maturity for a squad that was one of the youngest in the entire tournament.

Every nation prepared for one version of Spain and encountered a completely different one. Those expecting endless sideways passes were instead faced with quick vertical attacks. Those anticipating a fragile defence discovered a back line that relished physical battles. They made every new environment their own, turned every challenge into familiar ground. And they did so without losing their identity.

When La Roja opened its campaign with a frustrating goalless draw against tournament debutant Cape Verde, it



AP

gave critics ammunition to question its credentials. But Luis de la Fuente’s side, among the firm favourites early on, carried on unfazed.

If Austria was dismantled with authority, Portugal was bested through discipline. If Belgium was outmanoeuvred, France was comprehensively outplayed. If Argentina entered the final buoyed by Lionel Messi’s last dance, La Albiceleste found itself stripped of both sentiment and solutions, suffocated by a side that made sure the music stopped on its terms.

The famous 2010 side, led by Xavi Hernandez, Andres Iniesta, Xabi Alonso and Sergio Busquets, perfected possession football. They suffocated opponents with the ball and patiently waited to exploit the smallest defensive mistakes. While that side’s victories were often narrow, they rarely felt fortunate. This year’s champions inherited many of those principles but expressed them differently. If the 2010 side resembled an orchestra where every movement was carefully choreographed, this team felt more like a modern jazz ensemble. The

structure remained, but there was greater freedom within it.

Grace under pressure

Every great football nation has always had a personality. Brazil is celebrated for improvisation and individual creativity, Italy built its reputation on defensive intelligence, and Germany has often represented organisation, efficiency and physical strength.

At its heart, Spanish football has always been built on one simple conviction: the ball is the team’s greatest defender. At the grassroots level all around the country, children are taught that possession is not merely a statistic but a form of control. Keep the ball to dictate the rhythm, choose where and how the game is played, and, consequently, prevent the opposition from attacking. It is football choreographed by geometry, brought to life by instinct.

The results are as clear as day. The country has a conveyor belt of footballers who appear comfortable in situations that would unsettle most.

Those who come out of the Spanish system stand out immediately, and

their technical superiority puts them in high demand.

Its style is often unfairly reduced to one word: possession. But possession was never the true objective; control was. While most players would look at ways to run past opponents, those from the Spanish schools look for ways to make the opponent move first. They might not always dominate through physical presence, but they excel because they understand where the game is going before others do.

It is not just world-class players that Spain produces time and again, but also talented head coaches that have established themselves as the game’s best – like Pep Guardiola, Luis Enrique, the late Tito Vilanova, Unai Emery, Xabi Alonso and Andoni Iraola, to name a few.

De la Fuente has now taken his place among Spain’s best. Incidentally, his entry into the national system began with him answering a job advertisement posted by the Royal Spanish Football Federation (RFEF) for youth team coaches, 18 months after being sacked by Deportivo Alaves in 2011. Initially handed a temporary

contract, the 65-year-old steadily rose through the youth ranks, winning the Under-19 and Under-21 Euros, before eventually taking charge of the senior national team. Today, he is the oldest manager to win the World Cup.

Evolution without dilution

The 2026 World Cup-winning team took that Spanish identity and imposed it with ruthless precision. Across 39 days, Spain proved that brain could still triumph over brawn at the very top of international football.

Every great Spanish team has its roots set in midfield. This campaign was no different. Led by captain and Ballon d’Or holder Rodri, it controlled and dictated the speed of the match – slow when Spain needed patience and fast when opponents showed vulnerability. They controlled the match and refused to become frustrated even as the goal remained elusive. Argentina’s defence resisted wave after wave for 105 minutes. A dozen Spaniards had a crack at goal, and somehow Emi Martinez stood tall. Time was slipping away, yet Spain stayed patient and refused to take its foot off the gas until it got to a point where a breakthrough felt inevitable.

It eventually came from Ferran Torres, a player that few would have picked as a game-winner. Doubts on his abilities only grew stronger when he hit the bar rather than the back of the net against Cape Verde and Uruguay earlier in the tournament. But on the biggest stage, fate finally smiled on him, as Torres provided the release with Spain’s 20th shot of the night. In a tournament that featured the brilliance of Messi, Kylian Mbappe and Erling Haaland, Spain offered a different kind of reminder: that football’s greatest force is often not an individual, but an idea shared by eleven players.

If the first star on Spain’s shirt represents a generation that conquered the world by perfecting control, the second belongs to one that proved control could be reinvented. Perhaps Spain’s biggest triumph, as the confetti settles, is proving that its golden generation is not merely a chapter in the past.

THE GIST

When La Roja opened its campaign with a frustrating goalless draw against tournament debutant Cape Verde, it gave critics ammunition to question its credentials

But Austria was dismantled with authority, Portugal was bested through discipline, Belgium was outmanoeuvred, France was comprehensively outplayed

In a tournament that featured the brilliance of Messi, Mbappe and Haaland, Spain offered a different reminder: that football’s greatest force is often not an individual, but an idea shared by eleven players

In the eye of the storm

Dharmendra Pradhan

The Union Education Minister has tendered his resignation as protests over exam paper leak persisted, mounting pressure on the Narendra Modi government

Nistula Hebbar

Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation as Union Education Minister marks an unusual interlude in a political career that had enjoyed a steady rise. A controversy of such magnitude engulfed him that it became a contest between his staying in office and addressing the anxieties of an entire generation, with GenZ protests ultimately emerging victorious.

Nothing in Mr. Pradhan’s career had foreshadowed such a denouement. Born in Talcher, Odisha, in 1969, he comes from a family long associated with the Rashtriya Swayamsewak Sangh (RSS), the ideological parent organisation of the BJP. His father, Debendra Pradhan, was an RSS functionary, who joined the BJP in 1980. He was elected to the Lok Sabha from Deogarh and served as Union Minister for Surface Transport in the Vajpayee government from 1998 to 2001.

Mr. Pradhan started his political journey with the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), the student wing of the RSS, and later became a member of the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM), the youth wing of the BJP. He earned a degree in Anthropology from Utkal University in Bhubaneswar.

In an ironic twist, foot-



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

age of an ABVP protest march Mr. Pradhan led to the Odisha Assembly in 1997 against an alleged exam paper leak – and in which he was beaten by the police – has resurfaced amid the anti-NEET protests. The three-decade gap between the two events encapsulates not only Mr. Pradhan’s political journey but also the enduring problem of exam leaks and youth unrest.

He won his first Assembly election in 2000 from Pallahara, Odisha. His first Lok Sabha victory was in 2004 from Deogarh (when he also became national president of the BJYM). He then became the national secretary and national general secretary of the BJP and got elected to the Lok Sabha again in 2024. He has also served two terms as a member of the Rajya Sabha.

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi assumed office in 2014, Mr. Pradhan was made Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas, a position he would hold for seven years, becoming the

country’s longest-serving Petroleum Minister. He was the Minister when the Ujjwala Yojana of free cooking gas connections for the poor was launched. In 2021, he became the Education Minister, a portfolio that was ideologically most important to the Sangh Parivar.

Start of troubles

It is easy to assume that Mr. Pradhan’s troubles began with the leak of the NEET exam paper in 2024, just as the third Modi government took office. The repeat leak in 2026 may appear to have been the final straw. In reality, however, much like Mr. Pradhan’s own steady rise in the BJP, his political woes accumulated gradually, gathering momentum with each passing controversy.

It started with the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT), whose teacher training manual described sex as “biological” and gender as “a social construct” – Sangh Parivar sympathisers denounced

this formulation as pushing a “woke agenda”. This was followed by the University Grants Commission’s (UGC) ‘equity regulations’, which defined caste-based discrimination as discrimination “only on the basis of caste or tribe” against members of the Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), and Other Backward Classes (OBCs), while prescribing no penalties for false complaints against those from the General Category. Then came the NEET paper leak, complaints by students about the CBSE marking process, alleged security vulnerabilities and answer-sheet mix-ups.

The middle class saw its belief in professional qualifications as a pathway to social mobility being undermined under the watch of a government it had backed for more than a decade. The right wing felt Mr. Pradhan, distracted by state politics, had been asleep at the wheel – negligent when he should have been vigilant. With the youth enraged, the right wing apathetic, and the newly minted Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) deploying a new grammar of protest, a storm was beginning to form.

The steady ascent of Mr. Pradhan’s political career was halted by a generation-defining protest. For someone who hadn’t stumbled once on his way to the top, it was an unexpected slip.

Iran’s natural fortress

Pickaxe Mountain

The mountain range that U.S. President Donald Trump has threatened to strike is composed of volcanic rocks that could complicate efforts to penetrate deeply buried facilities

Vasudevan Mukunth

“We’ll be hitting that area very probably pretty soon, and there’s not a thing they can do about it,” U.S. President Donald Trump recently said about Pickaxe Mountain, a geological formation around 220 km south of Tehran.

The locals call it Kuh-e Kolang Gaz La. Recent satellite images showed a flurry of activity around the formation, including the movement of vehicles, and entrances to what appear to be tunnels. What is under the mountain is not clear, although Israeli intelligence seems to believe it houses a part of Iran’s nuclear programme.

Pickaxe Mountain is part of the Karkas Range, or Reshteh Kuh-e Karkas. It extends for more than 100 km in a northwest-southeast ‘diagonal’ between the cities of Kashan and Ardestan and is named for its highest summit, Mount Karkas, which rises to about 3.9 km above sea level in the midst of an arid plateau. The Range is part of the Urumieh-Dokhtar magmatic belt, and its mountains hold evidence of millions of years of volcanic activity and tectonic deformation. Specifically, the Urumieh-Dokhtar belt developed as the Neo-Tethyan Ocean subducted beneath the Iranian continental margin before



REUTERS

Arabia finally collided with Eurasia, in the last 66 million years.

The tectonic activity generated large quantities of calc-alkaline magma and thick lava flows and the attendant accumulations of volcanic breccia and ash deposits. Thus, much of the bedrock exposed in the Karkas Range consists of volcanic rocks such as andesite and rhyolite together with pyroclastic deposits and younger sedimentary units.

A 2019 study led by Panthea Giahchi of the Geological Survey and Mineral Exploration of Iran (GSMEI) reported that the landforms of the Karkas massif were shaped by rock type and climate together. The range sports steep ridges, landslide deposits, rock-falls, and extensive alluvial sediments. Andesite rocks generally form dense and mechanically strong masses and rhyolite rocks often (though not always) host many fractures.

According to some regional GSMEI maps, the Range is also dissected by

numerous faults, creating a structurally complex formation. This is why understanding how specific parts of the Range will respond to missile strikes and explosions is complicated.

Volcanic landscape

Within this craggy volcanic landscape sits Pickaxe Mountain, in the form of a ridge just south of Natanz. Despite its prominence, there appear to be no peer-reviewed geological studies of the mountain: most assessments in the public domain are based on geological maps and satellite data, and details extrapolated from what is known about the Karkas Range itself. GSMEI maps indicate that Pickaxe Mountain also consists of volcanic rocks such as andesite, rhyolite, dacite, and their associated pyroclastic units – and with variations in the lithology, density of fractures, faulting patterns, weathering, and groundwater intrusion together affecting its mechanical characteristics. Andesites, rhyolites, and volcanic tuffs transmit

seismic and shock waves differently from one another. The fault zones also create planes of weakness that in turn influence the stress response of the adjacent rock mass.

Geological uncertainty is often pronounced in projects involving volcanic rocks. To excavate Pickaxe Mountain itself, local experts might have characterised the rock units, charted their fractures and faults, tested their mechanical properties in the lab, and only then planned the excavation.

But as much as volcanic rocks complicate an excavation, they could complicate a bombing as well. In-tact andesite, dacite, rhyolite, and basalt often require more energy than many sedimentary rocks to fracture. And while natural fractures sound like flaws, they can scatter stress waves by splitting the energy up among many discontinuous formations.

In fact, Pickaxe Mountain may be a symbol of Iran’s geo-strategic riches. Its volcanic geology could make deep penetration more difficult. Any ground campaign would have to navigate a rugged landscape. And the surrounding maritime network has three major chokepoints – the Straits of Hormuz and Bab el-Mandeb and the Suez Canal – giving Iran and its allies outsized opportunities to disrupt maritime traffic.

China evacuates people, suspends rail services as Typhoon Noul nears



Turk's term as UN rights chief extended despite U.S. warnings



Venezuela notifies United Nations of pull-out from ICC, alleging 'bias'



Romania shoots down a second drone in 2 days: Defence Minister



Houthis fire missiles and drones at Saudi Arabia in response to strikes

Wildfires in Spain, France force over 2,60,000 to flee

Israeli troops round up Palestinians in West Bank village



Russian, Ukrainian officials report 14 dead in latest attacks

Bill in U.S. Senate seeks three-year pause on H-1B visas, codify \$100K fee

A composite image featuring a US flag, a US dollar bill, and a US Visa Application Form. The US flag is in the background, with the stars and stripes visible. A US dollar bill is placed over the flag, and a US Visa Application Form is in the foreground, partially overlapping the dollar bill. The form is titled "U.S. Department of State Application for USA Visa US H1B Visa Form".



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HARD-FOUGHT WIN

Sachin survives stern Canadian test to make pre-quarterfinals



PTI

India's Sachin Siwach survived a stern challenge from familiar foe Keoma Al-Ahmadih of Canada to enter the men's 60kg pre-quarterfinals of the Commonwealth Games boxing competition in Glasgow on Saturday. Sachin secured a 4-1 split decision victory in the first-round bout at the SEC Centre.

MIXED FORTUNES

Rupa and Pinki pair extends winning run; Sonowal loses



PTI

India's Rupa Rani Turkey and Pinki Singh recorded a third straight win and moved closer to the semifinal in women's pairs Section B of the lawn bowls competition at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. In men's singles, Putul Sonowal tasted his first defeat in Section D after notching up back-to-back victories.

MASTERSTROKE

We felt that the slower deliveries would be effective: Yash Thakur



BCCI

Debutant India bowler Yash Thakur, who returned figures of 4-0-30-2, said taking the pace off the deliveries proved a masterstroke. "Shreyas [Iyer] *bhai* and I discussed our plans before the innings. We felt that the slower ball would be a very effective option on this pitch, and it worked for us," Yash Thakur said.

LATEST UPDATE

Anahat is first Indian to emerge World junior squash champion



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Anahat Singh became the first Indian to be crowned World junior squash champion after she defeated Ruqayya Salem of Egypt in the summit clash at Ontario on Saturday. World No. 20 and top seed Anahat cruised past Salem 11-3, 11-7, 11-9. Anahat won a bronze last year after reaching the semifinals.

A tale of guts and glory as Jhandu opens tally

The para powerlifter from Bihar clinches bronze in the heavyweight category; head coach J.P. Singh appeals to the Central and State governments to provide a job for the medallist

C'WEALTH GAMES

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

It is not easy being Jhandu Kumar. For someone who has battled poverty for most of his life, winning the bronze medal in the men's heavyweight para powerlifting event of the Commonwealth Games at the Scottish Event Campus here on Friday was nothing short of extraordinary. When Jhandu won India's first medal of the Games amassing 130.9 points after successfully lifting 181kg and 190kg, it was around 9.15 p.m. local time, when most people back home were asleep.

But the handful of Indian supporters and officials at the venue applauded an athlete whose journey to the podium has been paved with hardship and sacrifice.

Nigeria's Idris Riluan scored 132.8 points to win the gold while England's Matthew Harding (131) bagged the silver.

"I would like to thank my coaches and parents," Jhandu said.

Staying calm

As each lifter let out a roar before attempting every bench press, Jhandu remained characteristically composed.

There was little outward emotion from the Indian, perhaps he had long internalised the pain and struggles that life had thrown at him.

Born in Harnaut in Bi-



Tough cookie: Jhandu has defied the odds to make it to the podium. GETTY IMAGES

har's Nalanda district, Jhandu comes from a humble family. The son of a vegetable vendor, he spent much of his childhood helping his parents. To supplement the family's income, he also took up odd jobs and even drove an e-rickshaw after the family's financial situation worsened.

When asked Jhandu about those tough years, he paused for a moment. He couldn't say much as he possibly reflected on the difficulties endured by both him and his family.

Before he could respond, J.P. Singh, head coach of the Indian men's and women's para powerlifting team, stepped in with an emotional appeal.

"I request both the Cen-

tral and State Governments to reward Jhandu appropriately and provide him with a job. He truly deserves it after everything he has gone through," Singh told *The Hindu*.

Jhandu's life changed when Paralympic medallist Rajinder Singh Rahelu spotted his talent and brought him to the Sports Authority of India's National Centre of Excellence in Gandhinagar, where he has trained ever since. Watching his protege deliver India's first medal of the Games was an emotional moment for the veteran coach.

A National champion while representing Bihar in 72kg in 2024-25 with a best lift of 205kg, Jhandu established himself as one of

India's brightest prospects in the sport by winning a bronze medal at the 2025 para powerlifting World Cup in Beijing.

"He can do even better and win gold medals at the World Championships," Rajinder said here on Friday. "He has excellent technique and, more importantly, he is mentally very strong."

Rajinder echoed those sentiments, praising Jhandu's calm demeanor and quiet determination.

As Jhandu was wheeled away after patiently obliging every interview request, he quietly acknowledged the congratulations from the volunteers, officials and passers-by with a gentle smile before exiting the venue.

Fine chance for India's promising weightlifters

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

The five-day weightlifting competition of the Commonwealth Games beginning at the Scottish Event Campus here on Sunday is packed with world-class talent.

The biggest star is Canada's Maude Charron in the women's 63kg category. A two-time Olympic medallist and World Championships medallist, Charron is one of the most accomplished athletes in the field.

Like India's Mirabai Chanu, the 33-year-old is chasing a third consecutive gold medal at the Games. Only three men – Precious McKenzie, Louis Martin and David Morgan – have performed the feat. No woman has achieved the distinction since women's weightlifting was introduced in the 2002 edition.

Another marquee name is England's Emily Campbell in the women's +87kg division. Campbell is a two-time Olympic medallist, having won silver at Tokyo 2020 and bronze at Paris 2024 (+81 kg).

Bindyarani Devi (58kg), Nirupama Devi Seram (63kg), Gyaneshwari Devi (53kg), Ajay Babu (79kg) and Raja Muthupandi (65kg) represent the next generation of Indian lifters.

India's chief coach Vijay Sharma has picked Gyaneshwari, Ajay and Raja as young lifters capable of winning medals.

It is an ideal opportunity for the next generation of lifters to step out of Mirabai's shadows, prove themselves on the international stage and ensure the country's rich legacy continues.

Kishan, Tilak and bowlers seal India's series victory



On the charge: Kishan and Tilak took the attack to the Zimbabwe bowlers. AFP & AP

INDIA IN ZIMBABWE

Press Trust of India
HARARE

Power-packed half-centuries from southpaws Ishan Kishan and Tilak Varma followed by a fine display from the bowlers helped India trump Zimbabwe by 90 runs in the second T20I here on Saturday. With the victory, the visitor took an unassailable 2-0 lead in the three-match series.

Chasing 220 was never going to be easy for the African side and the fate of the match was sealed when it lost five wickets inside nine overs. Eventually, the home team was bundled out for 129 in reply to India's 219 for five, which was constructed around Kishan's 81 (44b, 9x4, 2x6) and Tilak's unbeaten 60 (29b, 5x4, 3x6).

Kishan brought up his half-century off 31 balls, but the next 31 runs came off just 13 deliveries as he pressed on the accelerator. Tilak, for now, doused the

SCOREBOARD

INDIA
Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c Muzarabani b Ngarava 20 (9b, 3x4, 1x6), Abhishek Sharma c Burl b Muzarabani 8 (8b, 2x4), Ishan Kishan c Bennett b Nyamhuri 81 (44b, 9x4, 2x6), Shreyas Iyer c Evans b Bennett 25 (20b, 4x4), Tilak Varma (not out) 60 (29b, 5x4, 3x6), Rinku Singh c Burl b Evans 12 (8b, 1x6), Shivam Dube (not out) 6 (3b, 1x4); Extras (lb-2, nb-1, w-4): 7; Total (for five wkts. in 20 overs): 219.
FALL OF WICKETS
1-10 (Abhishek, 1.5 overs), 2-29 (Sooryavanshi, 2.6), 3-95 (Shreyas, 9.6), 4-189 (Kishan, 17.1), 5-213 (Rinku, 19.3).
ZIMBABWE BOWLING
Sikandar 4-0-47-0, Muzarabani 4-0-36-1, Ngarava 3-0-43-1, Evans 4-0-44-1, Nyamhuri 3-0-25-1, Bennett 2-0-22-1.
ZIMBABWE
Brian Bennett c Kishan b Yash Thakur 32 (19b, 3x4, 3x6), Ben Curran c Dube b Prince 1 (5b), Dion Myers b Bishnoi 12 (9b, 2x4), Ryan Burl c Rinku b Tilak 20 (18b,

2x4), Sikandar Raza c Kishan b Prince 0 (3b), Westly Madhevere c Shreyas b Dube 2 (3b), Tadiwanashe Marumani b Yash Thakur 24 (19b, 1x4, 1x6), Brad Evans b Abhishek 19 (11b, 1x4, 2x6), Newman Nyamhuri b Abhishek 3 (6b), Richard Ngarava c Rinku b Abhishek 1 (8b), Blessing Muzarabani (not out) 7 (6b, 1x4); Extras (b-2, lb-3, w-3): 8; Total (in 17.5 overs): 129.
FALL OF WICKETS
1-34 (Bennett, 3.5), 2-34 (Curran, 4.1), 3-48 (Myers, 5.5), 4-49 (Sikandar, 6.2), 5-65 (Madhevere, 8.2), 6-82 (Burl, 11.2), 7-105 (Evans, 13.3), 8-119 (Nyamhuri, 15.2), 9-121 (Marumani, 16.1).
INDIA BOWLING
Mayank 3-0-25-0, Yash Thakur 4-0-30-2, Prince 1.2-0-10-2, Bishnoi 4-0-20-1, Dube 1.4-0-13-1, Tilak 1-0-9-1, Abhishek 2.5-0-17-3.
Toss: Zimbabwe.
PoM: Kishan.

India won by 90 runs to lead series 2-0.
Third and final T20I: July 26 (Sunday), Harare, 4.30 p.m. IST.

talks about his strike-rate, playing a superb innings and reaching his fifty off only 23 balls. In the second essay, pacer Prince Yadav

(two for 10 off 1.2 overs) walked off with a clutched hamstring, raising questions about the team's injury management system.

Three contentious clauses likely to take centrestage in AITA EGM

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

With the Extraordinary General Meeting (EGM) of the All India Tennis Association (AITA) to ratify the new Constitution scheduled for Sunday in New Delhi, three contentious clauses are likely to take centrestage.

These concern the composition of the Executive Committee (EC), the upper age-limit for office-bearers and how their tenures will be calculated. In a 15-member EC, the National Sports Governance Act mandates at least two Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit (SOM) and two Athletes Committee (AC) representatives. But the Justice (Retd.) Gita Mittal-led panel has proposed five SOM and two from the AC to make it more athlete friendly.

As against the requirement of at least four of the 15 to be women (minimum of one each from SOM and AC), Justice Mittal's team has sought the inclusion of at least five women (one-third) so that floor-level representation is maintained even when there is a vacancy.

The Sports Act mandates an age ceiling of 70 years for EC members but in the same breath says that those between 70 and 75 "may contest" and serve a full term "if permitted by the International Charters and Statutes and the bye-laws". The AITA believes that since the 2026 Constitution of the International Tennis Federation only prescribes a lower limit (21 years) and is silent on an upper threshold, the ceiling can be raised to 75 years.

But the administrator's

team has argued that "may" limits the scope and the word "bye-laws" "envisages that the Bye-Laws of the National Sports body may restrict the age to 70 or below".

With regards to tenure, the Sports Act says a person is eligible if he or she is "not more than 70 on the last date of nomination for election".

It is to be noted that veteran administrator Anil Khanna is 73 and interim president Chintan Parikh will turn 70 in the near future. The administrator has also proposed that no EC member can hold office simultaneously in State associations, and governing bodies of other National federations except the Indian Olympic Association.

Further, the Delhi High Court, in its interim order dated June 18, had stated that all actions at the EGM

– including the scenario where the AITA does not adopt the proposals – would be subject to the final outcome of the main petition filed by players Somdev Devvarman and Purav Raja.

The administrator-appointed observers for the EGM will be Rakesh Munjal (senior advocate and president of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation in Law), Raj Liberhan (bureaucrat and former secretary, International Lawn Tennis Club of India), Lorren Bamniyal (former registrar, Delhi High Court) and Illa Rawat (former district and sessions judge, Delhi).

Also, the AITA, through ITF, had sought an observer from the Asian Tennis Federation, but it is reliably learnt that the concerned person pulled out on Friday.

UTT

Amol Karhadkar
PANAJI

U Mumba TT stayed on course to defend its title with a clinical 8-3 victory over a spirited HVR Kolkata Thunder Blades on Saturday, setting up a mouth-watering Ultimate Table Tennis Season-7 final against Dempo Goa Challengers at the Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium.

It was a complete team performance, orchestrated by the elegant Manush Shah, whose commanding display swung the semifinal decisively in U Mumba's favour.

After the opening two singles matches, the teams were locked at 3-3 in the race to eight games. From there on, however, U Mumba steadily tightened its grip.

The bespectacled Ma-



Swing factor: Hursey and Manush put U Mumba on the road to victory with a clinical performance. BUTTERFLY UTT

nush, the World No. 40, first teamed up with Anna Hursey to blank the Kolkata pairing of Ankur Bhattacharjee and Ayhika Mukherjee in the mixed doubles. Their crisp stroke-making and sharp anticipation left the Thunder Blades with little room to dictate rallies, handing U Mumba a crucial advantage.

Manush then carried the momentum into the

fourth singles against the flamboyant Ankur. Despite conceding an early lead, Manush repeatedly targeted Ankur's forehand corner, using a succession of forehand topspin winners to snatch the opening game.

Ankur briefly threatened a comeback in the second as his trademark backhand winners began to find their mark. But Manush's precision on serve

and receive kept him firmly in control. Fittingly, he sealed the contest with another ferocious forehand topspin that clipped the top-edge of Ankur's blade before flying long, prompting jubilant teammates to hoist him onto their shoulders.

Earlier, Romanian Eduard Ionescu had given Kolkata the perfect start by defeating Frenchman Lilian Bardet in the opening singles. Hursey then showcased her excellent touch and tactical awareness against Ayhika's awkward long-pimped rubber to restore parity, laying the platform for Manush to take centre stage.

The result:
U Mumba TT bt HVR Kolkata Thunder Blades 8-3 (Lilian Bardet lost to Eduard Ionescu 9-11, 10-11, 11-8; Anna Hursey bt Ayhika Mukherjee 11-8, 11-5, 8-11; Manush Shah & Hursey bt Ankur Bhattacharjee & Ayhika 11-7, 11-5, 11-2; Manush bt Ankur 11-7, 11-5).

INBRIEF



Carapaz’s 20th-stage win all but seals Pogacar’s crown

Tadej Pogacar, *in pic*, all but sealed a record-equalling fifth Tour de France title on Saturday as Ecuadorian Richard Carapaz won the 20th stage on Alpe d’Huez. With Sunday’s 21st and final stage of the 113th edition of the Tour likely to be the usual procession around Paris, Pogacar will need only to cross the finish line to secure a fifth Tour title in seven years. The Slovenian will join greats Jacques Anquetil, Eddy Merckx, Bernard Hinault and Miguel Indurain as the only riders to have won the event five times.

Sinner, Djokovic withdraw from Montreal Masters

Jannik Sinner and Novak Djokovic have pulled out of next month’s ATP Montreal Masters, organisers Tennis Canada said. World No. 2 Alexander Zverev is now expected to be the top seed.

Norris takes pole position for Hungarian Grand Prix

FORMULA ONE

Agencies
BUDAPEST

Defending Formula 1 champion Lando Norris took his first pole position of 2026 when he snatched it from Lewis Hamilton by just 0.012 of a second at the Hungarian Grand Prix on Saturday.

Hamilton was on course for a record-extending 105th pole position, and his first in a full Grand Prix since Hungary in 2023, before Norris darted through to take it away.

“It’s been a while,” Norris said. “I felt confident all weekend.”

Hamilton dropped to fifth in the grid after he was found guilty of impeding McLaren’s Oscar Piastri during qualifying.

The Australian driver gestured angrily at Hamilton after taking evasive action when he spotted his rival’s Ferrari going slowly on the inside of the first corner. Piastri was handed the fourth spot.

Asked what his main problem was in the qualifying session, Piastri said: “Lewis not looking in his mirrors.”

Ferrari’s Charles Leclerc will start in the front row with Norris while leader Kimi Antonelli of Mercedes will begin in the second row with Piastri.

Red Bull’s Max Verstappen will start sixth and Antonelli’s teammate George Russell seventh.

Mercedes could also be facing a repair job after Russell broke down on track on his way back to



Setting the pace: Norris has given a confidence boost to McLaren. REUTERS

the pits.

Norris felt he could easily have gone much faster if he’d had time for another run to iron out mistakes.

“I had the confidence to push more,” he said. “I got it to unexplored territory from what happens to the balance when I push it that next level, and I lost a bit of time in a couple of places.”

Back-up plans

Ferrari’s home circuit of Imola has emerged as a likely host for Formula One’s season-ending race if Grands Prix in Qatar and Abu Dhabi cannot go ahead due to conflict in the Middle East, with Malaysia set to return in October.

Qatar is due to host the penultimate round of the championship on November 29, with Abu Dhabi following on December 6.

The current plan is for both to proceed but informed sources indicated Imola’s Autodromo Enzo e Dino Ferrari, in the birthplace of Formula One chief

over, 2:30: 1. Valiant Stream (10) Akshay K 60, 2. Joondalup (2) Aleemuddin 59, 3. Invincible (9) Kiran Rai 56.5, 4. Small Dreams (1) A. Hangal 56.5, 5. Thessallian (4) Trevor 56.5, 6. Zephyrine (7) Pavan 56.5, 7. Steffen (6) S. Sachin 56, 8. Goddess Of War (8) Arul 55.5, 9. Kiss Of Grey (3) Saurav Rawat 55.5 and 10. Lasya (5) Neeraj 55.5.

1. THESSALIAN, 2. VALIANT STREAM, 3. INVINCIBLE

3. ESQUIRE PLATE (Div. I), 1,200m, maiden 3-y-o only (Terms), 2-00 p.m.: 1. Darringer (5) Arvind K 56, 2. Iron Flame (6) Vinod Shinde 56, 3. Act Of Kindness (1) Trevor 54.5, 4. Bay View (7) L.A. Rozario 54.5, 5. Como (8) Akshay K 54.5, 6. Qualify (4) Darshan 54.5, 7. Sindoor (2) Antony 54.5 and 8. Spark Of Life (3) Yash 54.5.

1. ACT OF KINDNESS, 2. SPARK OF LIFE, 3. IRON FLAME

2. LUMBINI STUD PLATE (Div. II), 1200m, rated 40 to 65, 4-y-o &

57, 4. Rodney (10) Pavan 56.5, 5. N R I Ace (2) Neeraj 56, 6. John Wick (1) Antony 55, 7. Stellantis (3) Trevor 55, 8. Felisa (9) A. Hangal 54, 9. Art Collector (4) Siddharaju P 53 and 10. Aquastic (2) Akshay K 52.

1. AQUASTIC, 2. RODNEY, 3. JOHN WICK

7. LUMBINI STUD PLATE (Div. I), 1200m, rated 40 to 65, 4-y-o & over, (Terms), 4-00: 1. Shamrock (8) Suraj 60, 2. Mayne Magic (5) Antony 57, 3. Alfonsine (6) Yash 56, 4. Nonpariel (2) Mukesh K 55, 5. Once You Go Black (4) Trevor 55, 6. Galahad (1) Akshay K 54, 7. Promiseofthefuture (7) Neeraj 54 and 8. Xanthe (3) Hindu S 52.

1. ALFONSINE, 2. MAYNE MAGIC, 3. ONCE YOU GO BLACK

6. SALAZAR PLATE (1,200m), rated 60 to 85, 4-30: 1. Cross water (5) Aleemuddin 60, 2. Don Carlos (7) Vinod Shinde 60, 3. Power Of Beauty (6) Lave Kumar



Combative: Anahat suffered a blip in the second game but came back strong to move one step closer to glory. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

SQUASH

Press Trust of India
ONTARIO

Anahat Singh became the first Indian to reach the World junior squash championship final since Joshua Chinappa achieved the feat back in 2005.

On Friday, the top-seeded 18-year-old defeated Egypt’s Barb Sameh 11-3, 8-11, 11-4, 11-6 in the last-four clash. “I feel really happy. I played against Barb at the British Junior Open a few months ago and it was a close match like this one, so I knew I would have to play really well,” said Anahat, who will cross swords with Egyptian second seed Ruqayya Salem in the title decider.

“I did not play my best yesterday (Thursday) and I knew that I had to come out today and show what I am capable of,” she said.

“I have played in four World Juniors and lost in the quarters and semis, so reaching the final has made my parents and coaches happy. The tournament is not done yet”.

CHESS

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

A formidable Indian squad has been named for the women’s event in the upcoming chess Olympiad and will be the pre-tournament favourite. However, the team captain Swayams Mishra is not leaving anything to chance.

The Indian team comprising Koneru Humpy, R. Vaishali, Divya Deshmukh, Vantika Agarwal, and B. Savitha Shri, will be among the strongest and Mishra said the focus will be on preparing well and taking it one match at a time.

“India will be among the strongest contenders. We have a balanced team, but the Olympiad is a long



Swayams Mishra. FILE PHOTO: BISWARANJAN ROUT

event, so our focus will be on preparing well and taking it one match at a time,” he told *The Hindu*.

He said there were plans to hold a preparatory camp before the Olympiad, subject to player availability.

The Indian women had a wonderful campaign in 2024 in Budapest, winning the gold ahead of power-

houses like China, the USA and Kazakhstan and Ukraine. This year’s tournament will be held in Samarkand (Uzbekistan) from September 15 to 27.

“China will be a major contender, along with teams like Georgia, Kazakhstan, Poland, Ukraine, and the USA. Every match will be challenging,” Mishra said.

The captain is quietly confident of the team’s prospects but struck a note of caution.

“Being the defending champions brings confidence, but this is a new Olympiad and every event starts afresh. The players are professionals who understand that past results don’t guarantee future success, so our focus will be on performing our best,” he added.

Bangladesh’s Nahid out of Australia Tests

CRICKET

Agence France-Presse
DHAKA

Fast bowler Nahid Rana has been ruled out of the upcoming Test series in Australia due to injury, the Bangladesh Cricket Board said on Saturday.

The BCB said the 23-year-old pace star suffered a side injury during the second T20 match against Zimbabwe last week.

“Rana is expected to require around four weeks for tissue healing, followed by another two to four

weeks of bowling workload progression, putting his overall recovery period at six to eight weeks,” it said in a statement.

Left-arm pace bowler Shoriful Islam, who also sustained a hamstring injury during the Zimbabwe tour, could make a comeback in the second Test, subject to medical clearance.

The 25-year-old would “undergo a fitness assessment around August 12”, the BCB said. Wicketkeeper Litton Das could also be available for the second Test if he recovers from a calf muscle injury, it said.

Shooters Sonam, Elavenil miss out on medals

Press Trust of India
HANGZHOU

India’s Sonam Uttam Maskar and Olympian Elavenil Valarivan produced strong performances to reach the women’s 10m air rifle final but fell short of the medals, finishing fifth and sixth respectively at the ISSF World Cup (rifle/pistol/shotgun) here on Saturday.

Only one silver

With no medal from the event, India continues to have just one silver from the competition, won by

Sainyam in the women’s 10m air pistol on Friday.

Sonam, the silver medalist at the 2024 ISSF World Cup Final in New Delhi, impressed in qualification, shooting 634.3 to finish second behind China’s Du Yuchen, who topped the field with 634.4.

Elavenil, a two-time Olympian and multiple World Cup gold medalist, also qualified comfortably after placing sixth with a score of 632.8.

However, the Indian duo could not replicate their qualification form in

the eight-shooter final.

Sonam bowed out in fifth place, while Elavenil followed in sixth as the Chinese shooters dominated the medal race.

Sixteen-year-old Du Yuchen claimed the first ISSF World Cup medal of her career, winning gold with a score of 254.6 in the final.

Japan’s Nobata Misaki settled for silver while China’s former world champion Han Jiayu took bronze.

India is tied for sixth with one silver medal, alongside two other nations.



Sahal leads Bagan to a win over East Bengal

DURAND CUP

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

Mohun Bagan Super Giant kicked off its Durand Cup campaign with a 1-0 win over arch-rival East Bengal FC, courtesy of Sahal Abdul Samad’s second-half strike in the Group A fixture here on Saturday.

With both sides missing several first-team players, neither of them started with a foreigner. The opening period was evenly contested as Bagan dominated possession while East Bengal looked dangerous on counter-attacks. Bagan created a few openings but lacked sharpness in the final third.

Sahal came up with a shot from inside the box in the 18th minute, but goalkeeper Prabhukhan Gill made a comfortable save.

The 29-year-old appealed for a penalty in the 24th minute after his attempted cross struck Jeakson Singh’s hand inside the 18-yard box. The referee, however, waved off the appeal.

Bagan finally broke the deadlock seven minutes after the interval. Kiyan Nasiri won possession near the East Bengal penalty area and delivered a low cross after driving into the box. Manvir Singh failed to connect with an attempted backheel flick, but Sahal arrived unmarked to slot home the eventual winner.

East Bengal introduced two foreigners – Mohammed Rashid and Daniel Ramirez – in search of an equaliser, but Bagan defended resolutely to preserve its lead.

The result: Mohun Bagan 1 (Sahal Abdul Samad 52) bt East Bengal 0.



Bundle of joy: Sahal celebrates with Thapa and Subhasish. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Alfonsine for Karnataka Mile Championship Cup

RACING

BENGALURU: Alfonsine, who has been expected to score in the Karnataka Mile Championship Cup (1,600m), the chief event of the races here on Sunday (July 26).

False rails (width about 5.5m from 1,600m to the winning post) will be in position.

1. ESQUIRE PLATE (Div. II), 1,200m, maiden 3-y-o only (Terms), 2-00 p.m.: 1. Darringer (5) Arvind K 56, 2. Iron Flame (6) Vinod Shinde 56, 3. Act Of Kindness (1) Trevor 54.5, 4. Bay View (7) L.A. Rozario 54.5, 5. Como (8) Akshay K 54.5, 6. Qualify (4) Darshan 54.5, 7. Sindoor (2) Antony 54.5 and 8. Spark Of Life (3) Yash 54.5.

1. ACT OF KINDNESS, 2. SPARK OF LIFE, 3. IRON FLAME

2. LUMBINI STUD PLATE (Div. II), 1200m, rated 40 to 65, 4-y-o &

60, 2. Glorious Strides (8) Md. Talib 59.5, 3. Siege Storm (9) Akshay K 58, 4. Badshaah (5) A. Hangal 57.5, 5. Bright Thunder (6) Antony 57.5, 6. Charlie Brown (4) Siddharaju P 57, 7. Stravinsky (2) M. Rajesh K 55.5, 8. Ziva (3) A. Asbar 54.5 and 9. Solara (1) Shreyas S 51.

1. BRIGHT THUNDER, 2. SIEGE STORM, 3. SOLARA

5. KARNATAKA MILE CHAMPIONSHIP CUP (1,600m), 4-y-o & over, (Terms), 4-00: 1. Shamrock (8) Suraj 60, 2. Mayne Magic (5) Antony 57, 3. Alfonsine (6) Yash 56, 4. Nonpariel (2) Mukesh K 55, 5. Once You Go Black (4) Trevor 55, 6. Galahad (1) Akshay K 54, 7. Promiseofthefuture (7) Neeraj 54 and 8. Xanthe (3) Hindu S 52.

1. ALFONSINE, 2. MAYNE MAGIC, 3. ONCE YOU GO BLACK

6. SALAZAR PLATE (1,200m), rated 60 to 85, 4-30: 1. Cross water (5) Aleemuddin 60, 2. Don Carlos (7) Vinod Shinde 60, 3. Power Of Beauty (6) Lave Kumar

Dream Seller clinches feature event

BENGALURU: Mr. Meher K. Sunderji’s Dream Seller (Trevor up) won the S.M. Cama Music And Production Pvt. Ltd. Bangalore City Sprint Championship Gold Cup (1,200m), the feature event of the races here on Saturday (July 25). The winner is trained by P.S. Chouhan.

1. BRAVE DANCER PLATE (1,800m): BLUE SAINT (Vivek) 1, Magna Carta (Antony) 2, Bruce Almighty (Akshay K) 3 and Art Of Romance (M. Rajesh K) 4. 1-3/4, 1-1/4 and 3/4. Im 56.83s. ₹94 (w), 26, 14 and 14 (p), SHP: 32, THP: 43, FP: 569, Q: 172, Trinella: 1,168/786, Exacta: 4,895/2,564. Favourite: Magna Carta. Owners: Mr. Waseem Dadapeer, Mr. Rohit Raman & Mr. Syed Imranuddin Mujahid. Trainer: Azhar Ali.

2. CAMINETO PLATE (Div. II), 1,200m: CHARACTER (Rafique S.K) 1, Rocking Star (L.A. Rozario) 2, Annabelle (Antony) 3 and Portieux (Trevor) 4. 1, 2-3/4 and Hd. Im 13.38s. ₹55 (w), 21, 10 and 22 (p), SHP: 27, THP: 57, FP: 318, Q: 119, Trinella: 1,784/1,147, Exacta: 4,321/1,567. Favourite: Rocking Star. Owner: Mr. Dinesh Kumar K. Trainer: Warren Singh.

3. RED DIVINE PLATE (1,100m): BORN TO RISE (Suraj) 1, Garzian (Jagadeesh) 2, Bellucci (L.A. Rozario) 3 and Shadai (Sai Kiran) 4. 9, 1 and Shd. Im 05.71s. ₹23 (w), 12, 12 and 52 (p), SHP: 32, THP: 104, FP: 69, Q: 34, Trinella: 2,070/1,109, Exacta: 9,775/2,327. Favourite: Born To Rise. Owners: Mr. Teja Gollapudi, Mr. Daulat Chhabria, Mr. Ashok Rampise, Dr. Prabhakar Chowdary Tripuraneni & Mr. Raghu S. Trainer: S. Narredu.

4. CAMINETO PLATE (Div. I), 1,200m: AGERA (L.A. Rozario) 1, Hushed (A. Asbar) 2, Zayana (Pavan) 3 and Aatherv (Rayan) 4. Not run: Elveden. 3/4, 13 and 21 (p), SHP: 26, THP: 43, FP: 834, Q: 294, Trinella: 4,469/4,309, Exacta: 19,246/8,248. Favourite: Aatherv. Owner: Mr. V. Shankar. Trainer: Pradeep Annaiah. S. S.M. CAMA MUSIC AND PRODUC-

TION PVT LTD BANGALORE CITY SPRINT CHAMPIONSHIP GOLD CUP (1,200m): DREAM SELLER (Trevor) 1, Reiko (Neeraj) 2, Czar (Aleemuddin) 3 and Kalamitsi (Akshay K) 4. 2-1/4, 2-1/4 and Nk. Im 12.13s. ₹15 (w), 10 and 12 (p), SHP: 23, THP: 56, FP: 24, Q: 12, Trinella: 165/141, Exacta: 211/52. Favourite: Dream Seller. Owner: Mr. Meher K. Sunderji. Trainer: P.S. Chouhan.

6. HONEY DAY PLATE (1,400m): BEAWADA BAASHA (Sai Kiran) 1, Feeling Good (Ritesh Gochhi) 2, Chotipari (Vinod Shinde) 3 and Ebote (Aleemuddin) 4. 4, 1/2 and 1-1/4. Im 26.99s. Rs. 104 (w), 36, 19 and 10 (p), SHP: 53, THP: 44, FP: 1,009, Q: 684, Trinella: 4,261/2,435, Exacta: 13,413/13,413. Favourite: Chotipari. Owners: Mr. Rahul & Mr. Mohammad Abdul Raheem. Trainer: Praveen Jesu.

7. XISCA PLATE (1,500m): FREDERIK (Akshay K) 1, Imperador (Pavan) 2, Shutterfly (Trevor) 3 and Yarra Yarra (Antony) 4. 4-1/4, 3 and 3-3/4. Im 31.24s. ₹25 (w), 13, 16 and

14 (p), SHP: 45, THP: 44, FP: 168, Q: 90, Trinella: 195/64, Exacta: 517/517. Favourite: Frederika. Owner: Mr. P. Arun Kumar. Trainer: S. John. Jackpot: ₹5,36,452; Runner-up: ₹45,982; Mini Jackpot: ₹29,298; Treble (i): ₹38,631; (ii): ₹1,989.

LIVE TELECAST

CWG 2026: Day 3, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 1 p.m.

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 4 & 7.30 p.m.

Zimbabwe vs India: Third T20I, Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & FanCode, 4.30 p.m.

Formula One: Hungarian GP, F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 6.30 p.m.

West Indies vs Pakistan: First Test, Day 2, FanCode, 7.30 p.m.



Water surge: Houseboats moored on the banks of the Jhelum river in Srinagar following heavy rain.



All-weather ride: A fisherman rows his boat on a lake amid an unusually heavy spell of rain in Srinagar.



Cause for concern: A man watches the swollen Jhelum river, after an intense spell of rain that lasted several days, in Srinagar.



Livelihoods lost: A municipal shopping complex lies in ruins after raging floodwaters from the swollen Sukhnag river washed away dozens of shops in Beerwah, Budgam district.

Upheaval in undulating valley

Water bodies swollen, crops submerged and structures damaged – an intense monsoon across the Kashmir Valley grinds daily life and local agriculture to a halt



Imran Nissar
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Torrential rain in recent days has disrupted normal life across Jammu and Kashmir. The intense monsoon has triggered landslides, flash floods, urban waterlogging, and agricultural distress, as well as inundating major rivers and water bodies across the region.

The Kashmir Valley saw an unusually intense spell of rain that lasted several days. The India Meteorological Department reported that Kashmir received 324.94% more rainfall than normal between July 17 and July 23. Because of the heavy rain, the Jhelum river and its main catchment area near the Lidder river swelled sharply, leading to severe flooding.

The rain also erased the region's seasonal rain deficit in just four days. Reasi district recorded the highest rainfall at 473.2 mm during the heavy wet spell from July 19 to July 24.

While Srinagar itself took a hit, the situation poses a threat to the region's agrarian economy. South Kashmir districts – including Anantnag, Kulgam, and Pulwama – have seen vast expanses

of low-lying paddy fields submerged.

The mid-summer period is a sensitive growth phase for paddy crops. Prolonged inundation threatens root health, hinders nutrient absorption, and risks significant yield reduction.

The region's famous apple orchards have also suffered due to waterlogged soil, prompting the Department of Horticulture to issue advisories urging farmers to clear drainage channels immediately to prevent decaying of roots and structural damage.

Meanwhile, swollen tributaries and rising levels in the Jhelum river have put rural and semi-urban populations on high alert. While main river discharge levels are being closely monitored by civil authorities, localised flash floods and landslips have damaged minor connectivity structures in foothill areas.

As field teams work to restore traffic and drain water from inundated centres, the agricultural community remains anxious as it awaits a drier weather to assess the full scale of crop damage across the Valley.



Slick streets: A view of a waterlogged road near the Ghanta Ghar (Clock Tower) in Srinagar.

Clopping along: A Kashmiri man rides a horse cart on a rainy day in Srinagar.



Sideline wagons: Trucks halted at Qazigund after landslides forced the closure of the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway.



Perilous perch: Houses seen along the banks of the Jhelum river flowing over the danger mark in Srinagar. Swollen tributaries and rising river levels in the region have put rural and semi-urban populations on high alert.



All that remains: People look on after floodwaters cause structural damage in Beerwah, a popular tourist destination.



Field study: A man walks through a paddy field in Kulgam. Prolonged heavy rain poses a threat to the local agrarian economy.

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